



Harmanpreet Kaur steps down as India captain

India's only World Cup-winning women's cricket captain Harmanpreet Kaur on Tuesday stepped down from her position in all three formats, saying that she has done her duty as leader and is now "ready to play for the love of the game again."

P6

Indo-US talks at 'plateau,' not a precipice

Politicians are generally circumspect when discussing bilateral ties with any other nation; they choose their words carefully, lest any utterance or phrase be misconstrued. Therefore, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman's remark on Monday.

P4

FinMin pushes private banks to widen financial inclusion

The Finance Ministry on Tuesday urged private sector banks to increase their participation in financial inclusion schemes including Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana (PMMY) and Stand Up India. Chairing a review meeting with heads of all Public Sector Banks (PSBs).

P7

Mahima Nambiar calls 'Comrade Kalyan' a fun entertainer

Actress Mahima Nambiar has joined hands with Sree Vishnu for the first time in Telugu film 'Comrade Kalyan' which is a period entertainer laced with humor, romance and drama. The actress said she enjoys the role of comic relief in Sree Vishnu's style.

P8

Simultaneously published from Hyderabad | Warangal | Tirupati | Vijayawada | Visakhapatnam | Khammam | Kurnool | Delhi: RNI No: DELENG/2017/74095

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WINDOWS

11 Indians injured after ships hit by projectile in Hormuz

NEW DELHI: Eleven Indian crew members were injured on Tuesday after a Panama-flagged commercial vessel was hit by a projectile while transiting the Strait of Hormuz, prompting a strong condemnation from India. The vessel, MT On Peace, carried 19 crew members, including 17 Indian nationals. In total, 12 crew members -- 11 of them Indian -- sustained injuries in the strike, according to the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA). "We condemn the attack earlier today on a Panama-flagged commercial vessel MT On Peace off the coast of Oman, where it was struck by a projectile while transiting the Strait of Hormuz," the MEA said in a statement. "Of the total crew of 19, 17 are Indian nationals. It is learnt that 12 crew members have been injured, including 11 Indian nationals," it said. The MEA said continuing incidents of attacks on shipping in the region remain a "cause of deep concern" for India. "We reiterate our call for an immediate cessation of such attacks in the interests of peace and stability in the region," it said.

4 cops dismissed for extorting money from jeweller

SHAHJAHANPUR: Four Uttar Pradesh constables have been dismissed from service for allegedly extorting money from a jeweller after threatening to implicate him in a false drug trafficking case, officials said on Tuesday. Superintendent of Police Saurabh Dixit said jeweller Sundaram, a resident of Jalalabad, had lodged a complaint at the Jalalabad police station on September 6, alleging that constables Virendra Kumar, Pankaj Kumar, Arun Kumar and Tushar Verma, posted at Tilhar police station, had taken him to a police outpost and subjected him to harassment. The constables allegedly threatened to implicate him as a "smack trafficker" and demanded money, Dixit said. According to the complaint, Sundaram's family members later reached the outpost and paid the demanded amount, following which he was released, the SP said. The four constables were suspended after a preliminary inquiry found them prima facie guilty, Dixit said.

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... Seems the court too has gone to the people's court, sir...

Vote theft attack escalates

Rahul accuses Modi, CEC of treason

PURNA SINGH
NEW DELHI

LEADER of Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi on Tuesday launched his strongest attack yet over the Opposition's "vote chori" campaign, accusing Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Home Minister Amit Shah, Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat of undermining the country's democracy. Gandhi described what he alleged had been done to the country as "treason" and warned that every person responsible would face investigation, insisting that "nobody will be spared".

Rahul Gandhi and party MP Priyanka Gandhi have been taken into police custody.

Gandhi's remarks came after more than 300 Opposition MPs from the Lok

Sabha and Rajya Sabha, including members of the BJD, attempted to march to the Election Commission of India office but were stopped by a heavy Delhi Police deployment. The MPs wanted to meet the CEC and the Election Commissioners to raise their concerns, but were prevented from reaching the Commission headquarters.

Speaking to reporters roughly 50 yards from the ECI office, Gandhi questioned the decision to stop elected representatives from meeting the poll panel. "We wanted to meet the CEC and the Election Commissioners, but we were stopped and prevented from going there," he said. After the march was halted, Gandhi, Wayanad MP Priyanka Gandhi and several other Opposition leaders staged a dharna inside Akashvani Bhavan, which is located next to the Election Commission office.

Congress leader questions the decision to stop elected representatives from meeting the poll panel; he warns that every person responsible will face investigation, insisting that nobody will be spared; Rahul claims democracy had been hijacked through what he repeatedly described as "vote chori"

Gandhi said the fact that more than 300 MPs could be stopped from meeting Election Commissioners raised fundamental questions about the functioning of democracy. "Don't know why 300 MPs were stopped. And we have been made to sit here just 50 yards away from the ECI office," he said, questioning what purpose democracy served if elected MPs could not meet the country's Election Commissioners. Turning his attack towards the alleged

manipulation of electoral processes, Gandhi claimed that democracy had been "hijacked" through what he repeatedly described as "vote chori". He accused Modi, Shah and Bhagwat of being involved, with Gyanesh Kumar allegedly facilitating the process. Gandhi said the issue was no longer confined to Opposition parties and claimed that people across the country were aware of what was happening. "The entire country knows that it has been hijacked by Modi,



Rahul Gandhi talking to mediapersons

Shah, Bhagwat with the help of Gyanesh Kumar through "vote chori," Gandhi said. He claimed that even police personnel deployed at the protest had told him they knew what was happening in

the country. Gandhi further asserted that investigations would be conducted against those he named. BJP MP and national spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi accused the Congress

of backing voting rights for absentee, relocated, deceased and duplicate voters without verification and questioned who the party intended to benefit through such a stance.

From Guj to Delhi: Cabinet celebrates Modi's 25 years

- The resolution highlighted Modi's focus on poverty alleviation, linking his personal experiences with schemes providing housing, water, banking and healthcare. It cited nearly 60 crore Jan Dhan accounts, over four crore houses and 25 crore people moving out of poverty
- Women's empowerment, youth opportunities, support for farmers and vulnerable tribal communities were also highlighted. The Cabinet cited around 3.5 crore Lakhpati Didis, the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam and PM-KISAN transfers exceeding Rs 4 lakh cr

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

The Union Cabinet hailed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 25 years of uninterrupted leadership as head of government, first as Gujarat



chief minister and later as prime minister, saying his journey was guided by the principle of "Nation First and Citizen First".

In a resolution adopted at its meeting, the Cabinet said three successive mandates in Gujarat and victories in three Lok Sabha elections reflected the "enduring trust" placed in Modi by the people.

Information and Broadcasting Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said the resolution highlighted 10 features linking Modi's Gujarat tenure with his leadership as prime minister.

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Women's empowerment, youth opportunities, support for farmers and vulnerable tribal communities were also highlighted. The Cabinet cited around 3.5 crore Lakhpati Didis, the Nari Shakti

Vandan Adhiniyam and PM-KISAN transfers exceeding Rs 4 lakh crore.

The resolution praised Modi's willingness to undertake politically difficult reforms, including GST and welfare delivery reforms, while promoting cleanliness, digital payments and local products.

It also highlighted infrastructure and self-reliance, noting that public capital expenditure rose from Rs 2 lakh crore to more than Rs 12 lakh crore and electronics production from around Rs 2 lakh crore to over Rs 13 lakh crore. Technology initiatives such as UPI, COVID-19 vaccine development and Chandrayaan-3 were cited as examples of India's growing capabilities.

The Cabinet also praised Modi's leadership on national security and diplomacy, citing surgical strikes, Balakot, Operation Sindoor, Article 370's removal, G20 leadership and India's Global South outreach.

3 men try to pull NE woman into car at 5-star hotel

NEW DELHI: Three men allegedly harassed a north-eastern woman and tried to forcibly pull her into their Mercedes car at a five star hotel in New Delhi's Chanakyapuri area, following which they assaulted her friends with hockey sticks and iron rods when they intervened, police said on Tuesday.

According to the complaint, the woman, who is a native of Nagaland,

had gone to the hotel with her friend. While they were returning from the washroom, the three accused, who were travelling in a white Mercedes car, allegedly approached them and tried to stop them and forcibly pull the woman into the vehicle.

When her friends came and opposed the accused, the latter allegedly attacked them with hockey sticks and iron rods, police said.

581 girl students receive bicycles

NEW DELHI: Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood on Tuesday distributed bicycles to 581 Class 9 girl students under the government's Vidya Vahini Yojana, aimed at making daily commute to school easier and promoting independence among girls.

The bicycles were distributed to students of Government Sarvodaya Kanya Vidyalaya and Government Girls Senior Second-

ary School in Janakpuri, according to a statement. Under the scheme, the Delhi government plans to provide branded bicycles to all 1.4 lakh girls studying in Class 9 across the city. Nearly 18,000 girls have received bicycles so far, it said. Addressing students, parents and school officials, Sood said the initiative was not merely about transportation but also about giving girls greater confidence and independence.

India aims to host 2036 Olympics

LAUSANNE

THE International Olympic Committee on Tuesday said India, Germany, Qatar and Turkiye are among seven countries with a stated interest in hosting the 2036 Olympics and have been invited to present their Games projects to the IOC's Future Host Commission next month.

The IOC said the projects will be assessed on a number of technical factors such as venue master-plan and athlete experience, funding strategy, political and public support, Games delivery capabilities, and legacy strategy to create long-term benefits for host communities.

The world body, however, did not share the exact timeline for these presentations. "The Interested Parties currently in Continuous Dialogue with the IOC, with a stated interest in hosting the 2036 Olympic Games, are (in alphabetical order): Germany, Hungary, India, Qatar, Republic of Korea, South Africa and Turkiye," read a statement from the

Ahmedabad is India's city of choice to host the mega-event, which has never been held in the country before. India submitted its Expression of Interest to host the Games in 2024



IOC. "There are also a number of NOCs taking part in noncommittal talks with the IOC about hosting future Olympic Games beyond 2036.

The Interested Parties have been invited to present their projects to the Future Host Commission in November," it added. The

IOC keeping this schedule in view, said no other Interested Parties will be considered for 2036 after October 31. Ahmedabad is India's city of choice to host the mega-event, which has never been held in the country before. India submitted its Expression of Interest to host the Games in 2024.

Man attacks live-in partner with acid after break up

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

A 24-year-old woman was allegedly attacked with acid by her former live-in partner in northeast Delhi's Bhajanpura on Tuesday after she broke up with him, police said.

The woman, who was on her way to work when the incident occurred, suffered serious burn injuries to her face, chest and thigh, and was initially



taken to Jag Pravesh Chandra Hospital. She was later referred to GTB Hospital in view of the severity of her injuries, police

said. According to police, the woman was walking to work in Gandhi Nagar around 6 am when the accused allegedly approached her from behind near a local crossing and threw acid on her before fleeing the spot.

The woman, in severe pain, sought help from an around 80-year-old man, whose left hand also suffered minor burn injuries during the incident, police said.

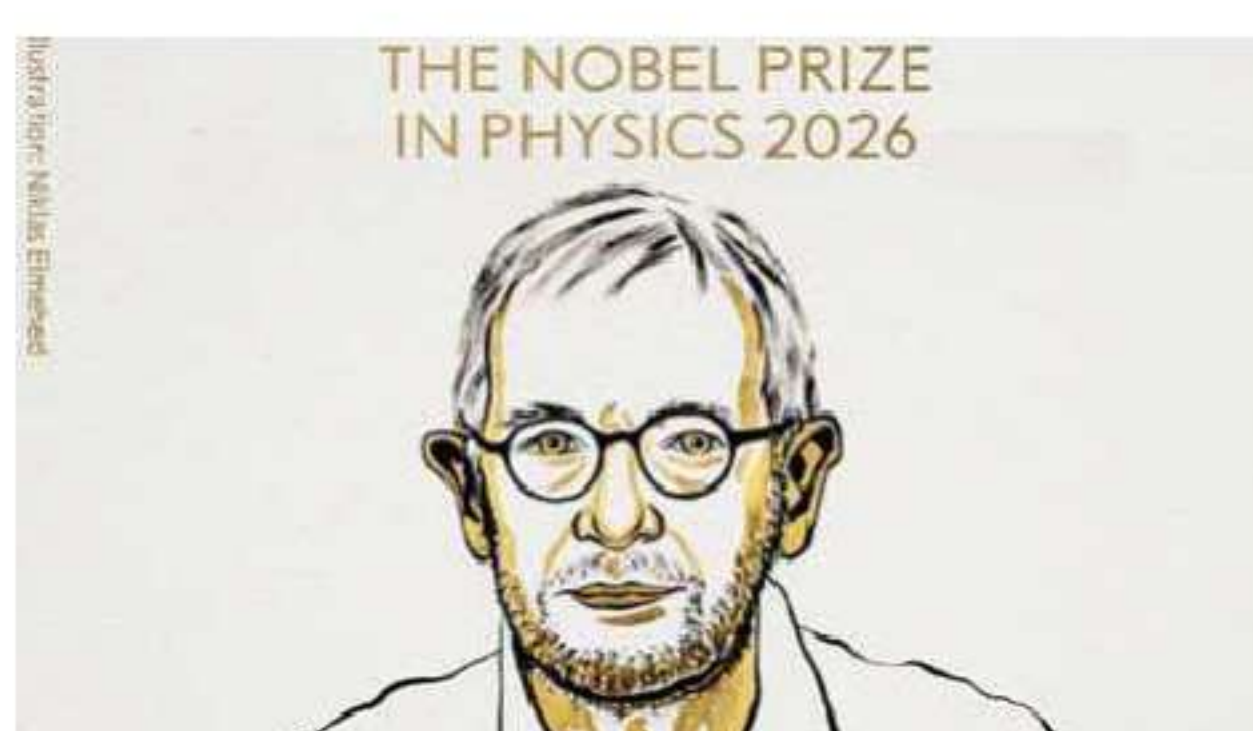
Physicist Francis wins Nobel Prize for IceCube neutrino discovery

STOCKHOLM

BELGIAN-born scientist Francis Halzen won the Nobel Prize in physics Tuesday for his efforts to demystify a rare group of neutrinos, tiny cosmic particles that researchers believe offer clues to how the universe evolved. "It was a great surprise, and I obviously didn't expect it," Halzen said, speaking to the Nobel Physics Committee by phone from Italy, in

The Belgian-born scientist said it was predicted that he would win the prize, but the announcement still made him feel strange

a call broadcast at the news conference to announce the winner.



Halzen said it was predicted that he would win the prize, but the

announcement still made him feel "strange." "I am working on a proposal, and

I hope that this prize will help getting it approved," he said to chuckles from the audience.

Neutrinos are tiny cosmic particles with no electrical charge and extraordinarily small mass, making them difficult to detect. Yet they are everywhere: They spew from stars like the sun, and trillions zip through our bodies every second. Scientists cannot glimpse the mysterious ghost particles zooming

around on their own, so they measure what happens when the particles collide with other bits of matter. Neutrinos bump into other particles only rarely, so scientists build large detectors to improve their odds of catching collisions. Halzen had the idea to turn the vast Antarctic ice into such a detector. The Nobel committee said his work was instrumental to the construction of the IceCube Neutrino Observatory in

Antarctica, which glimpsed the first high-energy neutrinos from faraway galaxies.

"This experiment in the Antarctic is a revolutionary way of understanding the universe that we didn't have before," said Michael Moloney, chief executive officer for the American Institute of Physics. When a neutrino interacts with ice in the detector, it produces a flash of light that's picked up by sensors.

Rawat holds march in Kumaon; defies high command's directive

HANS NEWS SERVICE
DEHRADUN

DEFYING the Congress High Command's directive, former Uttarakhand chief minister Harish Rawat led a march in Jaspur, Udham Singh Nagar district, on Monday and said he would explain it to the party's leadership in Delhi on Wednesday.

In a post on X, Rawat on Monday said, "It's possible I

have not been able to explain my point properly. Selja ji (Uttarakhand Congress in-charge) has given me time to meet on October 7 at 7 pm, and the party has the right to seek clarification."

Rawat organised this march following a letter from Congress General Secretary and Uttarakhand party in-charge Kumari Selja, in which she had advised him against proceeding with

Rawat organised this march following a letter from Congress General Secretary and Uttarakhand party in-charge Kumari Selja, in which she had advised him against proceeding with these programmes

these programmes. In her letter, Selja had noted that the party needs to present a united front for the upcoming assembly elections due in the coming months.

She had said, "You (Rawat) will understand that, at

this juncture, any such parallel programme would not be in the party's interest."

The senior Congress leader, however, emphasised that he could not understand how his 'Dhanyavad evam Jansamvad Yatra' was affect-

ing the party's programmes. There are no Congress programmes currently underway and no organised public outreach campaign is visible across the state, he said, questioning how his march was weakening the party's programmes.

Earlier, the yatra -- undertaken despite the High Command's strict instruction against organising 'parallel programmes' -- saw

the participation of former state president, Chakrata MLA, and Uttarakhand election campaign committee chairman Pritam Singh; Jaspur MLA Aadesh Chauhan; and numerous other leaders and party workers. During the march, Rawat said that his objective was to work towards ousting the BJP governments from both Uttarakhand and Uttar Pradesh. Rawat noted that



every key figure within the Congress party participated in the event in some capacity, and the march boosted party workers' morale. Ex-

pressing gratitude for the grand welcome, the Congress leader said, "Jaspur's support for this journey is as solid as a rock."

DA case: HC issues notice to Punjab CS

HANS NEWS SERVICE
CHANDIGARH

THE Punjab and Haryana High Court on Tuesday issued a notice to Punjab Chief Secretary K A P Sinha, asking him why criminal contempt proceedings should not be initiated against him for making a "prima facie false statement" in a case pertaining to the pending dearness allowance of employees and pensioners.

A bench of Chief Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra and justice Rohit Kapoor also asked the CS to remain present on Friday, which is the next date of hearing. The development came following a report by the high court registry from

Asks why criminal contempt proceedings shouldn't be initiated against him; a bench of Chief Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra and justice Rohit Kapoor also asked the CS to remain present on Friday, the next date of hearing



the Supreme Court registry regarding the state government's appeal status.

It showed that defects in the Punjab government's appeal in the Supreme Court have not been removed, which contradicted the stand of the Punjab CS that defects in its appeal have been cured. Petitioners' counsel Sunny Singla

said the high court issued a notice to the Punjab chief secretary, asking why criminal contempt proceedings should not be initiated against him for giving a "false statement".

Singla further said the court took note of the re-

port that defects in the Punjab's government's appeal have not been removed.

The court directed the high court registry to immediately get a report from the Supreme Court regarding the state government's appeal status. The court

was hearing pleas related to the non-compliance of the court's August 3 order of releasing DA and dearness relief dues to state employees and pensioners at the rates paid to the members of the All India Services (IAS/IPS/IFS) officers serving in the state on the Central government pattern.

The state of Punjab had filed a special leave petition in the Supreme Court on September 1 against the high court order, contending that the direction to pay arrears totalling around Rs 14,191 crore in such a short period was constitutionally impossible. On Monday, the bench rapped the Punjab government for playing 'hide and seek' with the court.

Prez: Docs duty-bound to display compassion towards patients

HANS NEWS SERVICE
BILASPUR

MEDICAL profession is not merely a means of livelihood but a supreme medium for compassion, sensitivity and selfless service to society, President Droupadi Murmu said while addressing the first convocation of AIIMS Bilaspur here on Tuesday. At the start of her address, the President paid obeisance to Mata Shri Naina Devi, the deity of the shakti peeth in Bilaspur.

She acknowledged Bilaspur's sacred soil and its historical significance. "I am delighted to visit this sacred abode of Goddess Naina Devi. Bilaspur is a land of heroes; its brave sons have sacrificed their lives to defend the nation. I respectfully salute all those immortal martyrs who contributed to India's security," she said.

On the occasion, the President felicitated five gold



medal winning students and distributed degrees to others. Congratulating the gold medallists and graduating students, she said it should be of immense pride for them to be part of the first batch of AIIMS Bilaspur.

She reminded them that their fundamental duty was not merely to diagnose and treat illnesses but also to demonstrate profound sensitivity and compassion to-

wards patients. When a patient receives empathy and a sense of personal connection with the doctor, half the battle against the ailment is won, the President said.

Noting that medical professionals often hesitate to serve in remote and inaccessible areas, she said the nation expects doctors graduating from prestigious institutions like AIIMS to rise above this mindset.

Need to wait and see how far SC rectifies voter deletions: Omar

HANS NEWS SERVICE
SRINAGAR

JAMMU and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah on Tuesday welcomed the Supreme Court's remarks questioning voter deletions under the Special Intensive Revision, but said it remains to be seen how far the court will go in rectifying it after taking responses from the Election Commission and the Centre. Abdullah also said the Uniform Civil Code (UCC) will not be implemented in Jammu and Kashmir as such a pan-India law ought to be debated and passed in Parliament. "It is good that the Supreme Court is also raising questions now, especially regarding the deletions that took place from the voter lists. The Supreme Court has also sought responses from the Election Commission and

the Government of India. To what extent this will be rectified through the court, we will have to wait and see," Abdullah told reporters here. Talking about the INDIA bloc MPs' march to the EC office, he said, "This process will continue. We had been raising this issue repeatedly, but very few people paid attention. Now the media has also started speaking about it," he said. On the UCC implementation, Abdullah reiterated that a Uniform Civil Code is not truly "uniform" until it is implemented everywhere. "We will not implement the Uniform Civil Code here. In Bihar as well, Nitish Kumar's party has said they will not implement it. Similarly, other governments have said the Uniform Civil Code will not be applied in their states. So, this is only being implemented by the BJP," he said.

BJP's countdown begins; INDIA bloc to form govt in UP: Shivpal

HANS NEWS SERVICE\
KANNAUJ

SAMAJWADI Party national general secretary and Jaswantnagar MLA Shivpal Singh Yadav on Tuesday claimed that the BJP government is on its way out and the INDIA bloc will form the government in the 2027 Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections. Speaking to reporters here, Yadav said the election would be fought under the leadership of SP president Akhilesh Yadav.

"The BJP government is going and its countdown has begun. The INDIA bloc will form the government in the 2027 Assembly elections," he said. Asked about



the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP) and the challenge it could pose in the elections, Yadav said the party's political existence had "ended". "The BSP has broken up. Whatever the BJP says, the BSP will do," he alleged.

On seat-sharing among the INDIA bloc constituents, Yadav said the decision would be taken by the national leadership.

Yadav also alleged that

the BJP indulges in "vote theft" and claimed that it also steals offerings made to God.

Asked about the Election Commission, he said people were now on the streets and demanded that elections should be conducted fairly.

"Elections should be held honestly," he said.

Yadav arrived in Kannauj in the afternoon and was accorded a warm welcome.

He attended a Shrimad Bhagwat Katha being held at the residence of SP leader Jai Kumar Tiwari 'Bauwan'. Speaking about his participation in the religious programme, Yadav said his family had always participated in religious events with faith and enthusiasm.

Raj revises panchayat poll schedule, advances 3 phases

HANS NEWS SERVICE
JAIPUR

THE Rajasthan State Election Commission on Tuesday advanced polling for the first three phases of the Panchayati Raj elections by a day, citing religious sentiments associated with the Dhanteras festival. Under the revised schedule, polling for Zila Parishad and Panchayat Samiti members in the first phase will now be held on October 22 instead of October 23, while voting for panch and sarpanch posts will take place on October 24 instead of October 25.

In the second phase, polling for Zila Parishad and Panchayat Samiti members has been advanced from October 29 to October 28, while voting for panch and sarpanch posts will now be held on October 30 in-

stead of October 31. Similarly, in the third phase, polling for Zila Parishad and Panchayat Samiti members will now be held on November 3 instead of November 4, while elections for panch and sarpanch posts will take place on November 5 instead of November 6.

The indirect election of deputy sarpanches by elected ward panchs will be held on October 25, October 31 and November 6 for the first, second and third phases, respectively. The commission said the schedule was revised keeping in view the religious sentiments associated with Dhanteras. Accordingly, polling parties for the Zila Parishad and Panchayat Samiti elections will now leave for their respective polling stations on October 21, October 27 and November 2 for the first three phases, respectively.

JK govt preparing new industry policy

SRINAGAR : The Jammu and Kashmir government is preparing a new industrial policy to rectify past mistakes and benefit the people, Deputy Chief Minister Surinder Chaudhary said here on Tuesday. "The government is bringing a new industrial policy, which is in its final stages. We are bringing a new policy because people were not happy with the previous one," Chaudhary told reporters here. The deputy chief minister said the government's efforts are to undo any discrimination that occurred under the previous industrial policy, or where a pick-and-choose system was practised. "Our effort now is to plug those bottlenecks and lapses, open things up, and ensure that people genuinely benefit from the industrial policy," he said.

Haryana expands Chirayu-Ayushman Bharat scheme to cover more families

HANS NEWS SERVICE
CHANDIGARH

HARYANA Health Minister Arti Singh Rao announced a major expansion of the Chirayu-Ayushman Bharat scheme on Tuesday, reiterating the state government's commitment to providing quality and affordable healthcare to every citizen. Under the expanded scheme, families with an annual income of more than Rs 1.80 lakh could avail the benefits by paying a nominal annual premium.

Eligibility will be determined based on the verified annual income recorded in the Parivar Pehchan Patra (family ID).



Eligible families will get free and cashless treatment up to Rs 5 lakh per year at empanelled hospitals across the state, she said.

Premiums have been fixed according to income slabs. Families with an annual income of Rs 1.80 lakh to Rs 3 lakh will pay Rs 1,500 per year; those in the Rs 3 lakh to Rs 6 lakh bracket will pay Rs 4,000; and

families with an annual income of more than Rs 6 lakh will pay Rs 5,000 per year.

The registration and payment gateway portal will remain open until November 30, 2026, while the new policy period will run from November 1, 2026 to October 31, 2027, Rao said here.

Highlighting the expansion of healthcare services in the state, Rao said that through the Ayushman Bharat Haryana Health Protection Authority, as many as 40,27,391 beneficiaries have so far received treatment under the Ayushman Bharat Pradhan Mantri Jan Arogya Yojana and Chirayu scheme at 1,307 empanelled hospitals across Haryana.

BJP's Dinesh Arya files RS nomination

HANS NEWS SERVICE
DEHRADUN

BJP candidate Dinesh Arya, a Scheduled Caste leader from the Kumaon region, on Tuesday filed his nomination for the election to Uttarakhand's lone Rajya Sabha seat, scheduled for October 16. Arya's nomination is significant as he is a Scheduled Caste leader from the Kumaon region, while all three Rajya Sabha seats in the state are currently represented by leaders from Garhwal, making his candidature a



move towards regional and caste balance ahead of next year's Assembly elections.

Arya filed his nomination papers with Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami, BJP state

president and Rajya Sabha MP Mahendra Bhatt, former chief minister Tirath Singh Rawat, several ministers and a large number of ruling party MLAs present. BJP media in-charge Manveer Singh Chauhani said Arya submitted his nomination papers to the Secretary at the state Assembly.

Tuesday was the last day for filing nominations. The seat is currently held by BJP's Naresh Bansal, whose six-year term ends on November 25. With the BJP holding 47 of the 70

seats in the state Assembly, Arya's election is virtually certain. The Congress has 20 MLAs, while the Bahujan Samaj Party has one and two seats are held by Independents.

Arya, a native of Haldwani in Nainital district, has been associated with the BJP for several decades and is considered close to Dhami. He began his political journey with the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) in 1985 before joining the Bharatiya Janata Yuva Morcha (BJYM).

Road closure forces villagers to carry woman's body 6 km on shoulders

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NAHAN

VILLAGERS in Himachal Pradesh's Sirmour district had to carry the body of an 80-year-old woman on their shoulders for nearly six kilometres to reach her village after a road damaged during the monsoon remained closed. Parma Devi, a resident of Tina Gularwala village in Dhageda panchayat of Nahan subdivision's Dharti Dhar area, died during treatment at

PGI Chandigarh. After her death, the body was brought by vehicle from Chandigarh to the main road connecting Dharti Dhar and Rama Dhageda. However, with the road ahead to Tina Gularwala closed, villagers tied the body to a pole and carried it on their shoulders for about six kilometres over a rough and uneven route to reach the village. The body was subsequently taken to the village's cremation ground for the last rites.

Villagers told PTI on

Villagers said that the road has been damaged since the onset of the monsoon and remains closed. This year, the monsoon arrived in Himachal Pradesh on June 30 and withdrew on October 3

Tuesday that the road has been damaged since the onset of the monsoon and remains closed. This year, the monsoon arrived in Himachal Pradesh on June 30 and withdrew on October 3. According to the villagers, the approximately eight-kilometre-long Tina Gularwala road was constructed

in 2014 and inaugurated by then Nahan MLA Rajiv Bindal.

The road connects Tina Gularwala, along with Bendli, Roz Katli and more than half a dozen other surrounding villages, to the Rama-Dhageda main road. Further ahead, the route passes through the Jal-

moosa river and connects with the Paonta Sahib-Kala Amb National Highway near Katsan Temple, close to Kolar village. Virendra Singh Thakur, a block development council (BDC) member from the area, said the consequences of the road closure were being felt not just in emergencies but in everyday life. "The consequences of the road closure are being suffered not only after death, but also in everyday life. Taking the sick to the hospital on time

has become a difficult task and farmers' crops are being ruined in the fields because they cannot be transported to the markets," he said.

Thakur said farmers, students and other villagers were facing severe difficulties due to the closure. He added that the road currently falls under the jurisdiction of the panchayat. "Every year, the Public Works Department restores the closed road, but this time the road remains closed," he said. Villagers Rohit,



Anil, Ramendra, Surendra and Pinku Singh told PTI that after the road was constructed in 2014, residents of

the area got road connectivity and transportation facilities for the first time since Independence.

Delhi boosts ASHA pay, rolls out newborn screening

PURNA SINGH
NEW DELHI

DELHI stepped up its health-care push with a series of new initiatives focused on frontline workers, newborn care, organ transplantation and digital governance, with the government doubling the monthly honorarium of 6,690 ASHA workers from Rs 3,000 to Rs 6,000. The announcements were made at the state-level "ASHA Sammelan-2026 and ASHA Samman Samaroh" at

The government also expanded Mission ANMOL, short for Advanced Newborn Monitoring and Optimal Life Care, to strengthen early detection and treatment of serious health conditions among newborns

Tyagaraj Stadium, organised under the Seva Sankalp Abhiyan, where Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta jointly launched the initiatives. The increase in ASHA work-

ers' monthly incentive was one of the key highlights of the programme and addresses a demand that had remained pending for years. Gupta also felicitated ASHA workers who had delivered outstand-

ing services and announced a special Dandiya programme for them during the upcoming Navratri celebrations. She said women who work every day to safeguard the health of families deserve dignity, recognition and care, adding that ensuring their welfare was a moral responsibility of the government. The government also expanded Mission ANMOL short for Advanced Newborn Monitoring and Optimal Life Care, to strengthen early detection and treatment

of serious health conditions among newborns. Under the programme, babies will be screened free of cost between 24 and 72 hours after birth for 63 serious genetic, metabolic and congenital disorders. Delhi plans to raise annual screening coverage from 1.5 lakh newborns to 2.5 lakh. According to the government, more than 75,000 children have already undergone screening and over 700 have received timely treatment after health conditions were detected. A

major digital reform was also introduced with the launch of the Nursing Home Management System portal. The platform is intended to simplify and digitise the administrative functioning of private nursing homes, with registration and renewal processes being shifted online. The government said the system would reduce repeated visits to government offices, improve transparency and make regulatory monitoring and administrative work faster and more efficient.



Temporary electricity connections within 24 hours during festival season

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

POWER discoms in the national capital have launched a "Tatkal" service for temporary power connections within 24 hours for the festival season, aimed at helping organisers of Durga Puja, Ramililas, Diwali melas and other events, including weddings. BSES Rajdhani Power Limited (BRPL) and BSES Yamuna Power Limited (BYPL) are gearing up to power the city's festivities.

The applicants can use websites, mobile apps and customer care of the discoms to apply for the temporary connections. The applicants can also make online payments for these temporary connections, said a BSES spokesperson.

Through its "Tatkal" temporary electricity connection service, BSES is facilitating same-day electricity connections for Durga Puja celebrations, Ramililas, Diwali melas, weddings and other events, he said.

Subject to completion of the prescribed formalities and technical feasibility, consumers can obtain a temporary electricity connection within 24 hours, he said.



Left student organisations to join October 10 protest

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

FIVE Left student organisations will join a protest scheduled at Jantar Mantar here on October 10 to demand the resignation of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and revocation of the Special Intensive Revision of Electoral rolls, according to a joint statement issued on Tuesday.

In the statement, the Students' Federation of India (SFI), All India Students' Federation (AISF), All India Students' Association (AISA), Progressive Students' Union (PSU) and All India Students' Bloc (AISB) said they would participate in the protest in large numbers. "Thousands, irrespective of their socio-cultural back-

grounds and political affiliations, have come together in defence of democratic values on which the imagination of modern India was built," the statement said.

The student organisations alleged that protests against the Election Commission of India and its functioning were being met with force by Delhi Police.

"Protestors are being manhandled, lathi-charged, dragged, assaulted and groped by Delhi Police. Even journalists are not being spared," they alleged.

The student groups said they were joining forces to build a broader movement and called upon democratic organisations and individuals who uphold constitutional values to participate in the October 10 protest.

Protest-related allegations CITY POLICE ARMS FRONTLINE PERSONNEL WITH BODYCAMs

A police source said the bodycams would help maintain a real-time video record of events and interactions between police personnel and protesters, besides providing evidence in case allegations are made against officers on duty

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

AMID allegations of excesses by security personnel during protests, Delhi Police has issued body-worn cameras to its officers and personnel deployed on the frontline across the New Delhi area, an official source said on Tuesday.

The bodycams have been issued to officers deployed across the New Delhi area, particularly those involved in crowd management and security arrangements around protest sites and roads leading to the Election Commission of India office, the source said.

A police source said the bodycams would help maintain a real-time video record of events and interactions be-



tween police personnel and protesters, besides providing evidence in case allegations are made against officers on

duty. "The bodycams are important, particularly when officers are dealing with large crowds, and there are allega-

tions from either side. The recordings can help establish what happened during a protest," the source said.

The move comes amid heightened security in the New Delhi, Central Delhi and North Delhi districts following a series of demonstrations against the Election Commission over the SIR exercise.

Police and paramilitary personnel have been deployed in large numbers, while multilayered barricades have been placed at several points to prevent protesters from entering restricted areas.

The deployment of bodycams assumes significance following complaints of alleged sexual harassment and manhandling made by three women journalists during a protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar at Jantar Mantar on October 2.

'Video of cop molesting journo at CEC protest via AI'

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

DELHI Police arrested a 24-year-old self-proclaimed independent journalist on Tuesday for allegedly circulating a fake video depicting ACP Vivek Bhagat sexually assaulting a woman. According to officials, the accused managed an Instagram account with nearly 24,000 followers. Nadeem Ahmed Ameen, a resident of Haryana's Palwal district, was apprehended from the Mewat region. Police recovered a mobile phone allegedly used to circulate the AI-generated reel from his possession.

Officials said they are probing whether this incident was part of a larger pre-planned conspiracy to malign the image of Delhi Police and spread dissatisfaction against the government.

Addressing a press conference, Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police (New Delhi) Manjeet said the accused claimed to be an independent journalist and



ACP Vivek Bhagat

was running the Instagram account '@news_aaina0776', which was created in April and had around 24,000 followers and 1,226 posts.

According to police, the manipulated video was circulated through this Instagram account and was presented as genuine CCTV footage, showing a person dressed as a police officer allegedly engaging in sexually inappropriate conduct with a woman. "Assistant Commissioner of Police Vivek Bhagat's photograph, name and designation were prominently displayed alongside the purported footage, falsely portraying him as the person involved," the officer said.

Court grants bail to 17 protesters

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

A court here has sought a report from Delhi Police on allegations of "custodial torture" levelled by two protesters arrested on Monday, as it granted bail to 17 people accused of unlawful assembly and obstructing public space, saying they are young and have their entire career ahead of them. The court also emphasised that while any person has the right to protest peacefully, assaulting police officials on duty is a matter of serious concern which cannot be permitted under the garb of peaceful protest.

The order was passed on Monday night by duty judicial magistrate Animesh Kumar after the 17 were arrested while they were protesting outside the Parliament Street Police Station earlier in the day, demanding registration of an FIR against a

police officer alleging that he had molested a woman journalist during that protest on the SIR row.

The court noted that according to the investigating officer (IO), the accused had been arrested as they were part of an unlawful assembly and had obstructed or blocked the public space where prohibitory order was in force, and, besides, when they were being detained, they manhandled the police officials, including a woman police official.

It noted that the police alleged that they also broke the window glass and the back side glass of a bus in which they were being kept, and that they did not cooperate during the investigation.

The court said the counsel for the accused argued that out of around 50 persons who were allegedly protesting, only 17 had been arrested and no CCTV footage of the alleged incident was brought on record.



Court grants regular bail to Swatantra Bhardwaj

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court on Tuesday granted regular bail to self-styled Hindutva influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj in a case concerning the alleged assault of the father of a student activist during the CJP protest at Jantar Mantar. Additional Sessions Judge Saurabh Pratap Singh Laler passed the order after earlier giving Bhardwaj interim bail for three weeks and observing his conduct during the period.

The detailed bail order is awaited. The court on September 15 granted Bhardwaj interim bail for three weeks, saying his conduct would be taken into account while deciding his plea for regular bail.

While granting interim relief, the court imposed several conditions on Bhardwaj, including a direction not to post, publish or discuss the case, his defence or the complainant's family on social media or any other media platform. He was also directed not to contact the complainant, his daughter or any witness and not to interfere with the evidence in the case. While granting the interim bail, the court had stressed that bail was an expression of the court's trust and "not a trophy to be displayed".



98 dengue cases in 1st week of Oct, tally touches 695

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

DELHI recorded 98 fresh dengue cases in the first week of October, taking the cumulative tally so far this year to 695, with the city having reported its highest monthly count of the disease in September, according to a Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) report.

The national capital recorded 286 dengue cases and 124 malaria cases in September -- the highest monthly figures for both diseases so far this year. In August, Delhi reported 90 dengue and 53 malaria cases.

According to the weekly vector-borne disease report for the week ending October 3, Delhi recorded 98 dengue and 23 malaria cases in October so far, taking the cumulative number of malaria cases this year to 266.

No deaths due to dengue or malaria have been reported in the city in 2026 so far, the report said. Delhi also reported two fresh chikungunya



cases in the first week of October, taking the monthly tally to two.

The city had recorded eight chikungunya cases in August and five in September. With the latest cases, the cumulative number of chikungunya cases in Delhi has reached 29 this year. No deaths due to the disease have been reported so far.

The MCD said vector-control and enforcement measures were being carried out across all civic zones to check the spread of mosquito-borne diseases.

Terrible traffic jam in Lutyens' Delhi amid INDIA bloc march

From India Gate and Connaught Place to Parliament Street and Jantar Mantar, bumper-to-bumper traffic built up on several stretches, with vehicles inching forward amid diversions and intermittent stoppages

HANS NEWS SERVICE
NEW DELHI

BARRICADES, diversions and security restrictions turned key roads in Lutyens' Delhi into long stretches of slow-moving traffic on

Tuesday, as the INDIA bloc's march towards the Election Commission disrupted movement across the New Delhi area.

From India Gate and Connaught Place to Parliament Street and Jantar Mantar,

bumper-to-bumper traffic built up on several stretches, with vehicles inching forward amid diversions and intermittent stoppages. At several points, long queues spilled back onto adjoining roads as motorists strug-



gled to find alternate routes through the heavily barricaded area.

The congestion left commuters stranded for prolonged periods, with several saying they were stuck for at least an hour. Some commuters abandoned their vehicles and switched to the Metro or walked to reach destinations in central Delhi, while visuals showed vehicles packed tightly along stretches affected by the restrictions.

Traffic was severely affected on the Connaught Place,

Patel Chowk, Rafi Marg, Parliament Street stretch, Motilal Nehru Marg, Teen Murti Marg, Prithviraj Road, Windsor Place, Ashoka Road, and Jantar Mantar Road.

"Traffic was moving at almost zero speed and the queue barely moved. We were stuck for nearly an hour before some of us decided to get down and take the Metro instead," a commuter stuck on Ashoka Road said.

Traffic was also affected across the New Delhi area, with movement hit on Krish-

na Menon Marg, Rajpath and Circular Road, while heavy congestion was reported at several roundabouts around India Gate. Another commuter reported a complete traffic jam from Mori Gate roundabout towards Hamilton Road and Pul Dufferin rail over bridge.

Another commuter said roads around India Gate were heavily congested, with restrictions and diversions on several routes making it difficult to move between adjoining areas.

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Indo-US talks at 'plateau,' not a precipice

POLITICIANS are generally circumspect when discussing bilateral ties with any other nation; they choose their words carefully, lest any utterance or phrase be misconstrued. Therefore, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman's remark on Monday that the India-US trade deal talks have hit a plateau is unusual and significant; she said at present giving or taking might be "very, very" difficult. A few days ago, United States Trade Representative (USTR) Jamie Green said that signing of the India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement was not "imminent" with the two countries having identified a "universe of items that are sticking points." This is unfortunate. Something seems to have gone wrong since February 7, when the two

countries issued a joint statement in which they were "pleased to announce that they have reached a framework for an interim agreement regarding reciprocal and mutually beneficial trade (interim agreement)." Many contentious issues were resolved. India agreed to eliminate or reduce tariffs on all US industrial goods and a wide range of US food and agricultural products, including dried distillers' grains (DDGs), red sorghum for animal feed, tree nuts, fresh and processed fruit, soybean oil, wine and spirits, and additional products.

The US agreed to apply a reciprocal tariff rate of 18 per cent on Indian goods, including textile and apparel, leather and footwear, plastic and rubber, organic chemicals,

home décor, artisanal products, and certain machinery. The two countries committed to provide each other preferential market access in sectors of respective interest on a sustained basis and address non-tariff barriers. They also agreed to work towards further expanding market access opportunities through the negotiations of the BTA and strengthen economic security alignment to enhance supply chain resilience and innovation. India intended to purchase \$500 billion of US energy products, aircraft and aircraft parts, precious metals, technology products, and coking coal over the next five years. Both countries wanted to "significantly increase trade" in technology products, including graphics processing units (GPUs)

and other goods used in data centres, and expand joint technology cooperation.

Hence, statements by Sitharaman and Green hint at a chill, much of which pertains to the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act of 2026, which President Donald Trump signed into law, giving himself the authority to impose tariffs up to 100 per cent on countries, including India and China, which buy Russian oil and gas. But diplomacy, like politics, is the art of the possible, so thaw in the bilateral relations should not be ruled out. It is true that the Lindsey O Graham law introduces an additional complication into an already delicate negotiation; also, Washington has its own geopolitical and economic compulsions,

particularly its determination to squeeze Moscow's energy revenues and discourage third countries from sustaining Russia's war economy. This, however, doesn't mean that all is lost. To be sure, neither India nor the US has an interest in allowing a potentially transformative economic partnership to be derailed by a single contentious issue. Both sides have much to gain from expanded trade, resilient supply chains, technology cooperation and strategic convergence. What is required now is political dexterity: Washington must recognise our strategic constraints, while New Delhi must remain willing to negotiate hard on trade-offs. A plateau need not become a precipice; with pragmatism and patience, the talks can move forward.



LETTERS

Prof Palle Rao exemplified humility

THE glowing tribute paid to Prof Palle Rama Rao (THI Oct 6) shows what a university head can be. Eminent scientists often turn into distant administrators, but Prof Rao lived in the campus, remained approachable and made a gardener's job permanent after he was in service as a temporary employee. True leadership is always judged by the lives it lifts, not the rankings it chases. Universities need more such leaders with proven vision and humanity.

Sakshi Raj, IIMC, Dhenkanal

An eye-opener for TN contenders

THIS is further to the editorial, "TVK and Vijay in a battle of prestige," (THI Oct 6). The upcoming Tamil Nadu by-elections mark a decisive, high-stakes battle for the state's restructured political landscape. For the ruling TVK, it is a referendum on governance and Vijay's ability to convert stardom into administrative credibility beyond the honeymoon period. A strong showing is essential to prove its historic victory was not merely a transient wave. For the DMK, coming off an unexpected and humiliating defeat, this contest is crucial to test whether its core Dravidian base remains intact and to reclaim its authority as the principal opposition force. For the AIADMK, embroiled in splits and leadership fractures, the bypolls pose an existential test of whether it remains a viable alternative or risks political irrelevance. Together, these verdicts will shape the 2026 assembly arithmetic and future alliances.

N Sadhasiva Reddy, Bengaluru-560056

Advantage TVK

THE Vijay show has just begun in Tamil Nadu, and indications are that he will pocket both seats that are up for grabs in the by-elections, including Maduranthakam and Dharapuram. The DMK has already lost them following their childish fault-finding against the Chief Minister. The sad reality is that the family is yet to come to terms with the dismal defeat, having grossly undermined the prospects of Vijay becoming the next chief minister of the state.

K V Raghuram, Wayanad

Learning lessons for Vijay

WITH reference to "TVK and Vijay in a battle of prestige" (THI, October 6), the bypolls offer Vijay a political lesson. A strong public following can provide an initial advantage, but electoral politics demands patience. TVK must build community relationships, understand local concerns and maintain a visible presence beyond campaign periods. It should clarify its position on education, jobs, urban development, agriculture and welfare. At the same time, established parties should respond to the challenge through better governance rather than merely attacking the newcomer. Ultimately, performance will matter more than publicity.

M Barathi, Bengaluru-560076

Hone competitive spirit

THIS is further to "TVK and Vijay in a battle of prestige" (THI, October 6). The bypoll results may generate speculation, but they should not be treated as a verdict on Tamil Nadu's electoral future. Bypolls are shaped by local issues, candidates, alliances and turnout, and therefore have limited value as indicators of mood. TVK should shed overconfidence after a good result or discouragement after a loss. Its priority should be to strengthen grassroots organisation and policies. A competitive environment will be healthy when leaders concentrate on public service, accountability and alternatives instead of reducing contests to a battle of prestige.

Pon Arunkumar, Namakkal-637202

Striking future alliances

PROPOS "TVK and Vijay in a battle of prestige" (THI, October 6), the contest matters greatly because it could influence future alliance calculations. A new political force can alter existing equations, but its long-term strength will depend on whether it can expand beyond the leader's personal popularity. TVK should work patiently on constituency-level organisation and maintain dialogue with voters on everyday issues. It must also demonstrate internal democracy and transparent candidate selection as it grows. For established parties, the lesson is equally important: complacency can create space for alternatives. Voters will judge all sides by their policies, credibility and capacity to deliver, not merely by campaign rhetoric alone.

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BENGALURU ONLINE

State faces Rs 3,006 crore traffic fine backlog despite repeated discounts

BENGALURU: Karnataka is facing a massive backlog of unpaid traffic penalties, with more than 5.53 crore violation cases remaining unsettled despite repeated 50 per cent discount schemes introduced to encourage motorists to clear their dues.

According to the available data, 8.16 crore traffic violations were recorded across the State between 2019 and August 2026. Of these, 5.53 crore cases remain pending, involving fines estimated at ₹3,006.70 crore. Bengaluru accounts for a substantial portion of the outstanding amount. Of the 5.85 crore traffic violations registered in the city, more than 3.72 crore cases are yet to be cleared. The unpaid fines in Bengaluru alone have crossed ₹2,048.56 crore. The issue has gained importance following the Supreme Court's recent observations on mounting e-challan arrears. The court has called for stronger recovery measures, including possible action against vehicles with unpaid penalties and restrictions on certain online transport services. Police authorities are considering several measures to improve recovery. Director General and Inspector General of Police M.A. Saleem said making payment of pending traffic fines mandatory for obtaining a vehicle Fitness Certificate is among the proposals under examination.

Read more at
<https://epaper.thehansindia.com>



PROF RAMAKRISHNA
GOLLAGARI

INDIA has made significant progress in closing the gender gap, but the latest global evidence shows that the country still faces a major challenge: turning women's gains in education into equal opportunities in employment, income, leadership and decision-making.

The Global Gender Gap Report (World Economic Forum, 2026), covering 145 countries, gives India a gender parity score of 64.5 per cent and ranking it 131st. Globally, 69.2 per cent of the gender gap has been closed, up 0.4 percentage points from the previous year, but full parity could still take about 120 years at this pace.

Among economies continuously assessed since 2006, the global score has risen from 64.2 per cent to 69.4 per cent. Iceland leads with 93 per cent, followed by Finland, Norway and Namibia. The evidence shows that gender equality depends not only on income, but also on effective institutions, public policies, education, employment opportunities, social conditions and women's political representation.

Educational equality:

There is remarkable progress in education attainment. Globally, 96.9 per cent of the educational attainment gap has been closed, while health and survival stand at about 96.2 per cent. In

contrast, economic participation and opportunity have reached only 61.7 per cent, and political empowerment just 22.1 per cent. In many countries, girls have entered schools and universities in large numbers and have achieved educational outcomes comparable to or better than boys. But education has not automatically produced equal job opportunities. The estimated time required to close the remaining global gap could take around 129 years, while political parity could take about 194 years at the current pace. The challenge is therefore no longer only to educate women, but to ensure that education translates into jobs, earnings, entrepreneurship, management positions and political influence.

The Indian case:

India's educational attainment score is 96.6 per cent, with full parity in secondary and tertiary enrolment and a 14.7-point improvement since 2006. Adult literacy parity has also risen to 82.5 per cent. However, this educational progress has not translated equally into economic opportunities. Economic participation and opportunity stand only at 41.2 per cent, ranking India 143rd among 145 economies, while labour-force participation parity is at 44.1 per cent. Women's representation among professional and technical workers has improved from 26.6 per cent in 2006 to 49.9 per cent in 2026, but remains only 13.1 per cent among legislators, senior officials and managers. Thus, India has made substantial progress in educating women, but the greater challenge is creating a stronger pathway from education to employment, economic independence and leadership.



Education:

A degree does not automatically guarantee a job. Women's participation in the labour market is influenced by the availability of suitable employment, workplace safety, mobility, childcare responsibilities, social expectations and the flexibility of working arrangements. The problem is especially important because women who leave education with qualifications may still face difficulties entering or remaining in paid employment. A woman may be well educated but unable to accept a job because of inadequate childcare, unsafe transport, family responsibilities or limited employment opportunities close to home. This is why India's next stage of gender development must focus not only on schools and colleges but also on employment and the workplace. Equal access to jobs must be accompanied by equal pay, opportunities for promotion, safe working conditions and access to leadership positions. Women entrepreneurs

also need better access to credit, technology, markets and business networks.

Political empowerment

India's political empowerment score is 24.5 per cent, considerably higher than its economic participation score, and India ranks 67th globally on this dimension. But the level of representation remains limited. Women account for only 16.1 per cent of parliamentary representation, while the ministerial-level parity score is only 5.9 per cent. The global picture is also similar. Political empowerment remains the weakest, with only 22.1 per cent of the global gap closed. Although progress has occurred over the past two decades, the political gains have also shown signs of reversal in recent years. Political representation matters because decisions about education, health, employment, childcare, taxation, social protection and economic development are ultimately made through political institu-

tions. Women's participation in these institutions is therefore an important component of gender equality.

Regional comparison

These differences suggest that countries need to look beyond income levels and examine the policies and institutions that enable women to participate fully in economic and political life. India's overall score of 64.5 per cent is the same as South Asia, but both are below the global average of 69.2 per cent. South Asia has closed only 40.9 per cent of its economic participation and opportunity gap. In contrast, Europe has closed 75.7 per cent, North America 75.2 per cent, Latin America and the Caribbean 74.5 per cent, East Asia and the Pacific 70.3 per cent, and Sub-Saharan Africa 68.8 per cent. These differences suggest that policies and institutions, not income alone, are crucial for women's economic and political participation.

The real challenge:

India's gender story is one of uneven transformation. While educational attainment has reached 96.6 per cent parity, with full parity in secondary and tertiary enrolment, economic participation remains much lower at 41.2 per cent. The key challenge is therefore to convert

educational gains into economic opportunities through market-relevant skills, formal employment, equal pay, leadership opportunities, affordable childcare, safe transport, credit access and flexible work. Changing social norms is equally important, particularly by reducing the disproportionate burden of unpaid household and care work on women.

Equality of opportunity:

The latest global report offers India both encouragement and a clear warning. The country has demonstrated that rapid progress in girls' education is possible. The next challenge is to achieve comparable progress in employment, earnings, management, entrepreneurship and political representation. The crucial question for India's gender development is not how many girls are entering colleges. But what happens to these educated women after they leave college? If education is successfully converted into productive employment, higher incomes, entrepreneurship and leadership, the benefits will extend beyond women themselves. Families, businesses and the wider economy can gain from a larger and better-utilised pool of human talent.

Conclusion:

India's gender challenge has therefore entered a new phase: from educating women to empowering them economically. The evidence shows that educational equality is underway. The real test now is whether India can ensure this educational equality is followed by equality in work, income, leadership and decision-making.

(The writer is a retired Professor of Economics, OU and visiting Professor, CESS, Hyderabad)

Gyanesh Kumar: Can a CEC under a cloud continue in office?

WHEN THE REFEREE BECOMES THE SUBJECT OF SERIOUS QUESTIONS, DEMOCRACY CANNOT LOOK THE OTHER WAY

DR MUCHUKOTA SURESH BABU

THE Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) is not an ordinary constitutional functionary. He is the custodian of the ballot, the guardian of electoral rolls and the referee of India's democratic contest. Above all, the CEC must command public confidence that every voter is treated equally.

That confidence is now under serious strain.

A media report claimed that Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi recorded objections on 14 occasions in 10 months over decisions and processes concerning electoral rolls, voter registration, deletion and restoration of names, and access to the voter database. The Election Commission has acknowledged the existence of the notes, while maintaining that the decisions were ultimately unanimous. But that does not eliminate the questions raised by the objections.

14 objections cannot be routine stuff:

Disagreement within a constitutional body is not itself the problem. What demands scrutiny is the frequency, subject matter and substance of the objections. According to the investigation, the concerns went to the heart of the electoral process: who can be added to the rolls, who can be removed, who controls the electoral database and how decisions affecting voters are recorded.

Form 6: Who has the power to change the rules?

The controversy over Form 6 is particularly significant. The two Election Commissioners reportedly objected to SIR-related changes introduced on the ECINet portal for new voters, calling the changes "illegal" and "unauthorised" and arguing that statutory forms could not be altered without following the prescribed legal process. For a young citizen seeking to exercise the constitutional right to vote for the first time, the electoral system should provide clarity—not burden them with more hurdles. The fundamental question is simple: Can an administrative authority effectively rewrite a statutory form through software without following the procedure prescribed by law?

If the answer is no, accountability cannot end with correcting the software after the controversy erupts.

When software becomes more powerful than the officer:

An even deeper concern is the reported centralisation of electoral-roll control. Few days back 97 voters in Goa, who were found eligible by the Electoral Registration Officer could not immediately be restored because the central software did not permit the officer's decision to be recorded.

This raises a fundamental democratic principle:

Technology may assist the law. It cannot replace the law. An algorithm cannot

not acquire authority that Parliament has not granted it. If a statutory officer has the power to determine a voter's eligibility, a software platform controlled elsewhere cannot silently nullify that authority.

The Commission therefore owes citizens a transparent answer: who controlled the system, who authorised the architecture, who could override whom, and what audit trail existed?

The voter and the commission's mistakes:

The larger concern is what happens when legitimate voters disappear from the rolls.

If the State removes a citizen from the electoral roll by mistake, the burden of correction should not simply be transferred to that citizen.

A citizen should not have to prove his right to vote all over again because the State failed to protect it in the first place. The vote is not a favour granted by the Election Commission. It is a legally protected democratic entitlement subject to the qualifications prescribed by law.

The credibility test:

The Supreme Court is now examining petitions challenging aspects of Gyanesh Kumar's functioning and the nationwide Special Intensive Revision exercise. The petitions raise allegations concerning unilateral decision-making and the legal basis of the SIR process. These are allegations before the Court, not judicial findings of wrongdoing.

The distinction matters:

The CEC cannot answer a crisis of institutional confidence merely by saying that procedures were followed. The public is entitled to know what procedures were followed, by whom, under what authority and with what safeguards.

Independence must be visible:

The Election Commission does not merely have to be independent. Its independence must be visible and credible. That requires transparency in decision-making, respect for the statutory powers of Election Registration Officers, meaningful consultation among all three election commissioners and complete accountability for changes affecting the electoral roll.

The CEC must be above suspicion—not because criticism is prohibited, but because the office is too important to operate under a persistent cloud of doubt.

Question bigger than Gyanesh:

The real issue is not whether Gyanesh Kumar is politically popular or unpopular. It is whether the institution he heads commands sufficient public confidence to conduct elections whose results will be accepted by citizens across political divisions.

The reported internal objections, the Form 6 controversy, questions over centralised electoral software and the judicial challenges to the SIR process have created a situation that demands independent scrutiny. Gyanesh Kumar

AP intensifies SC battle for 34% BC reservations

• Ram Mohan Naidu says legal route offers hope of securing reservation beyond 50 per cent ceiling; ministers consult senior advocates

• Govt says quota could secure 16,800 local-body positions for BCs; accuses YSRCP of blocking political empowerment

HANS NEWS SERVICE
AMARAVATI

THE state government has stepped up its legal battle to restore 34 per cent reservation for Backward Classes (BCs) in local body elections, turning to the Supreme Court after the High Court's ruling restricted the state's ability to implement the quota beyond the 50 per cent reservation ceiling.



Information and public relations and housing minister K Parthasarathy, along with civil aviation minister K Ram Mohan Naidu and other state ministers at AP Bhavan in New Delhi on Tuesday

Ram Mohan Naidu said on Tuesday that the government approached the Supreme Court because a legal avenue existed to secure the BC quota. He said the state was examining the issue on the basis of empirical data, judicial precedents and the High Court's orders, while seeking a solution without further complicating the matter.

Ram Mohan Naidu, along with agriculture minister K Atchannaidu, revenue minister Anagani Satya Prasad

and information and public relations minister Kolusu Parthasarathy, held discussions with legal experts and senior advocates in Delhi. The ministerial team consulted former attorney general Mukul Rohatgi and senior advocate Devadatt Kamat on the way forward.

Ram Mohan Naidu said several states were also exploring ways to secure BC reservations through inclusion in the Ninth Schedule, underscoring the wider constitutional and legal

debate surrounding quotas exceeding the 50 per cent ceiling.

He accused the YSRCP of working against the interests of BCs and questioned its opposition to the reservation. "This is not a political issue but a matter of social justice," he said, stressing that implementation of the 34 per cent quota could provide around 16,800 elected positions to BCs in panchayats, municipalities and other local bodies. Atchannaidu said the

government would pursue the legal battle "until the last moment" to restore the 34 per cent quota. Recalling the evolution of BC political representation, Atchannaidu said former chief minister N T Rama Rao introduced 20 per cent reservation for weaker sections in local bodies in 1987, while Chandrababu Naidu subsequently raised it to 34 per cent in 1995. He alleged that the previous YSRCP government reduced the quota from 34 per cent to 24 per cent without a legislative amendment or approaching the Supreme Court.

Parthasarathy said the objective was not merely to provide a token quota but to ensure political and democratic empowerment of BCs. He cited Articles 243D and 243T of the Constitution, arguing that the state was exercising its constitutional mandate to ensure adequate representation of weaker sections in local bodies.



Health minister Y Satya Kumar Yadav, along with MLAs Yarlagadda Venkata Rao, Venigandla Ramu, Kumar Raja and Kagittha Krishna Prasad and officials Veera Pandian and K V N Chakradhar Babu, inaugurating new health facilities across 24 districts from Janardhanavaram in Nandivada mandal of Krishna district on Tuesday

Quality healthcare will reach every village, says Satya Kumar

- 267 new health buildings inaugurated simultaneously across State
- 4,400 Ayushman Arogya Mandirs to be completed in six months
- Digital health records and mobile medical services to strengthen care

HANS NEWS SERVICE
VIJAYAWADA

MINISTER for health, medical and family welfare Y Satya Kumar Yadav said the state government was rapidly strengthening health infrastructure to provide quality medical services closer to people in rural and tribal areas.

The minister, along with government whip and Ganavaram MLA Yarlagadda Venkata Rao, Gudivada MLA Venigandla Ramu, Pamaru MLA Varla Kumar Raja and Pedana MLA Kagittha Krishna Prasad, inaugurated a newly constructed village health clinic building at Janardhanapuram in Gudivada division of Krishna district on Tuesday.

On the occasion, 266 more health buildings were inaugurated virtually across 24 districts, taking the total number of buildings inaugurated simultaneously to 267. The buildings, spread across 87 Assembly constituencies,

were constructed at a cost of around Rs 105 crore, he said.

Speaking on the occasion, Satya Kumar said the government aimed to complete the remaining 4,400 Ayushman Arogya Mandir buildings within the next six months. As part of the plan, 2,700 new buildings would be ready by the end of this year. Arrangements were being made to organise the next inauguration programme through Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, he said.

He said more than 4,400 village health clinic buildings, including those left incomplete by the previous government and newly sanctioned ones, were being completed with an allocation of Rs 1,128.02 crore under various schemes.

The minister said Ayushman Arogya Mandirs were being established at the rate of one for every 5,000 population. Each centre would provide 14 types of diagnostic tests, 105 types of medicines and 71 types of medical equipment. Services would focus on early detection of hypertension, diabetes, maternal and child health issues, eye and oral ailments, geriatric conditions and communicable diseases.

He said the government was also introducing the 'Sanjeevani' system to digitally maintain individual health records and provide each person with

a unique health identification number. The system would store details of tests, medicines, doctors' advice and hospital treatment. Around 2,500 coordinators would help connect people with telemedicine, medical consultations and hospital appointments, with the services targeted for launch from January 1.

Satya Kumar said 930 mobile health centres were being established to take medical services to remote villages. Each vehicle would have facilities for 41 types of tests and an auto-analyser worth around Rs 10 lakh. The vehicles would visit villages once every six months and provide several tests free of cost.

He said the government was focusing on prevention and early detection rather than treatment after diseases had advanced. He added that 1,644 village health clinics had so far secured National Quality Assurance Standards recognition, including 752 in 2024-25 and 892 in 2025-26. In Gudivada constituency, 41 Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, three block public health units and one primary health centre were being established, he said.

Health secretary Veera Pandian, commissioner of health and family welfare K V N Chakradhar Babu, Krishna district collector D K Balaji and several officials participated in the programme.

'Stree Shakti' crosses 100 cr free journeys, saves women Rs 3,550 cr

HANS NEWS SERVICE
AMARAVATI

THE state government's 'Stree Shakti' free bus travel scheme for women has crossed the milestone of 100 crore journeys, with Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu describing the achievement as a reflection of the scheme's growing acceptance among women across the state.

Launched on August 15 last year, the scheme has emerged as a significant component of women's daily mobility, with an average of 24 lakh women availing themselves of free travel every day, according to the Chief Minister.

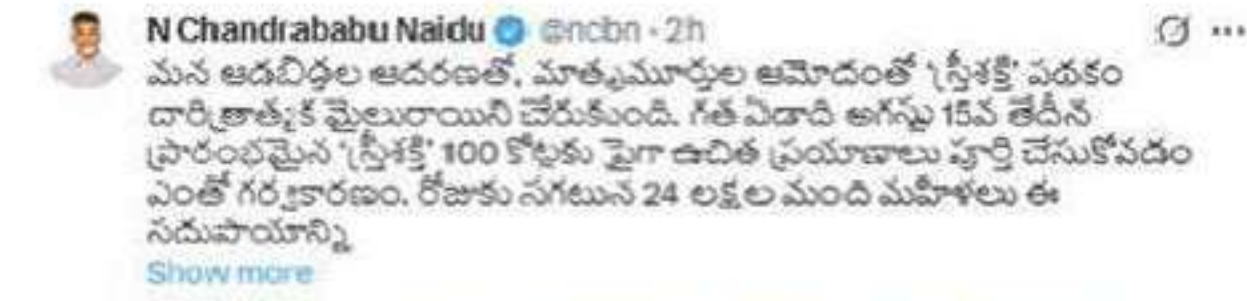
Naidu said the scheme had particularly benefited

students, working women and those travelling regularly for employment and other daily needs. By eliminating the cost of bus travel, it had reduced the financial burden on women and enabled them to travel more freely, he said.

The cumulative savings to women through the scheme have reached Rs 3,550 crore, he said, stressing that the money saved could be redirected towards children's education, household requirements and the future needs of families. Describing the crossing of 100 crore journeys as a "historic milestone", Naidu attributed the success to the enthusiastic response from women and the support of mothers across the State.

He congratulated the

women who had embraced the scheme and expressed appreciation for the APSRTC management and its staff, whose efforts, he said, had helped make the programme a large-scale public service success. Meanwhile, APSRTC chairman K Narayana Rao congratulated the corporation's drivers, conductors, supervisors, officers and other staff for their role in implementing the scheme. He said the staff had been providing services responsibly despite the substantial increase in the number of women passengers. APSRTC was also focusing on maintaining bus schedules, passenger safety, service quality and effective deployment of its fleet to meet the increased demand,



he said. The state government has been providing Rs 160 crore per month to APSRTC towards reimbursement under the scheme, with Rs 2,160 crore released up to August 2026, he added.

Narayana Rao said the scheme was applicable to eligible women, girls and transgender persons living in

Andhra Pradesh on specified APSRTC services, including Pallevelu, Ultra Pallevelu, City Ordinary, Metro Express and Express buses.

He said APSRTC was committed to continuing the scheme effectively, with a focus on women's welfare, economic empowerment and accessible public transport.

Telangana meets record power demand without cuts: Bhatti

Ministers inspect Pulichintala hydel power station; review its generation capacity

- State's peak power demand now risen to 20,000 MW
- Hydel generation declined by about 4,000 MW due to drought-like conditions
- This had created an additional burden of nearly 8,000 MW, said the Dy CM

DEEKONDA RAVI SHANKAR
HUZURNAGAR

DEPUTY Chief Minister Bhatti Vikramarka said Telangana was supplying uninterrupted power to consumers despite a sharp rise in peak demand and a decline in hydel generation caused by inadequate water availability.

Bhatti said the State's peak power demand, which stood at around 15,000 MW during the corresponding period earlier, had now risen to nearly 20,000 MW.

At the same time, hydel generation had declined

by about 4,000 MW due to drought-like conditions and reduced water levels in rivers and reservoirs. "This had created an additional burden of nearly 8,000 MW," he said.

Bhatti, along with Irrigation Minister N Uttam Kumar Reddy, inspected the Pulichintala hydel power station and reviewed its generation capacity and performance.

He also visited the unit control room and reviewed a presentation by officials.

Speaking to the media, Bhatti said all hydel projects in the State were ready to op-



erate at full capacity and that the decline in generation was solely due to inadequate water availability. Rising temperatures and deficient rainfall had aggravated the situation, he said.

The government remained committed to providing 24-hour power supply to domestic consumers, particularly during peak night-time

demand, which was being met through thermal power generation, he said.

Bhatti noted that Telangana's peak demand had reached the same level as Karnataka, which has a peak demand of around 20,000 MW, while Andhra Pradesh's demand stood at about 12,000 MW.

He urged people to use

water judiciously, warning that inadequate rainfall could lead to water scarcity in the coming months. Water should be conserved for drinking needs of people, livestock and birds until the next monsoon, he said.

Bhatti congratulated GENCO employees for their efforts in maintaining uninterrupted power supply.



Several BRS leaders join Cong in Dharmagadda Thanda

MLA Yashaswini Reddy welcomes new entrants, assures phased development works in the area

HANS NEWS SERVICE
HANUMAKONDA

SEVERAL BRS ward members and key leaders join the Congress party in DharmagaddaThanda of Devarupulamandal in Palakurthi constituency on Tuesday.

They say they are joining Congress, citing the state government's development and welfare programmes and its PrajaPalana initiative.

The joining programme is

organised under the leadership of village Congress president and former sarpanch candidate MoodaChandanaDevender.

Palakurthi MLA MamidalaYashaswini Reddy welcomes the new entrants by draping Congress scarves around their shoulders.

Speaking on the occasion, Yashaswini Reddy says the government led by Chief Minister Revanth Reddy is focusing on welfare, develop-

ment and infrastructure for all sections.

She assures residents that pending development works in DharmagaddaThanda will be taken up in phases.

Those joining Congress include ward member Bhukya Bikini and leaders BhukyaSrinivas, BhukyaSomla, BanothSrinivas, Muda Mahesh and Muda Manoj. Several Congress leaders and local representatives attend the programme.

Bar owners meet Excise Commissioner over key issues

HANS NEWS SERVICE
KARIMNAGAR

A delegation of bar and restaurant owners from the district met Chevuru Hari Kishan, Commissioner of Prohibition and Excise, in Hyderabad, on Monday and submitted a representation highlighting issues affecting the sector.

The delegation, led by Karimnagar District Bar and Restaurant Owners Association president Ponnala Tirupathi, general secretary Maddi Ramesh Goud, honorary president



and state vice-president Bairam Padmaiah and other members, met the Commissioner following the statewide shutdown call by the Telangana Bar and Restaurant Owners Association.

The delegation primarily raised concerns over permit rooms allegedly being operated illegally or in viola-

tion of regulations near licensed bars. They urged the Excise department to ensure that such establishments function strictly in accordance with the prescribed rules.

The representatives also explained that bar and restaurant owners were already facing financial difficulties due to taxes and rising operating costs, and that the proposed privilege tax would place an additional burden on the industry.

During the discussion, Commissioner Chevuru Hari Kishan reportedly examined the tax calculations

and observed that bars were subject to a higher tax burden compared with liquor sold through wine shops.

The Commissioner assured the delegation that their concerns would be brought to the government's notice and that appropriate steps would be considered, the representatives said.

They expressed hope that a favourable response would be received from the government within a week. The delegation thanked bar and restaurant owners across Karimnagar district for supporting the shutdown and participating in the programme.

NORTHERN RAILWAY	
Tender Notice	
The Dy. Chief Electrical Engineer/Gati Shakti Unit/Delhi, DRM Office, New Delhi-110055 invites e-tender for the following work:	
Name of Work and Location	Balance Electrical Work of Lighting and Power Supply arrangement for SZM, NUR, GHNA, BVH, PTRD, FDN and other Railway Stations of DLI Division under Amrit Bharat Scheme
Tender Notice No.	31-R-DyCEE-GSU-DLI-26-27
Earnest Money Amount (to be deposited online)	Approximate Cost
₹5,75,900.00/-	₹2,87,93,633.31/-
Date & Time for Submission of e-Tender and Opening of Tender	
Tenders uploaded on date 05.10.2026 on IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in. The bidders can participate in the e-tender, the tender will be opened at 11:30 Hrs on 02.11.2026.	
Detailed Tender Notice & Tender Document	The detailed e-tender notice is available on Northern Railway website i.e. www.nr.indianrailways.gov.in and tender document is available on www.ireps.gov.in.
Above tender document will be available for submission of offer on IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in from 19.10.2026 to 02.11.2026.	
All other terms and conditions in respect of the above tenders are given in tender document.	
The detailed tender notice also can be seen on the Notice Board of the above office.	
No. 31-R-DyCEE-GSU-DLI-26-27	Dated: 05.10.2026
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE	



Now, it is time for me to turn the page. Captaincy may end today, but my love for Indian cricket never will. Blood. Sweat. Sacrifice. Pride. I gave it all. Now, I'm ready to play for the love of the game again. Captaincy ends. The journey continues.

Harmanpreet Kaur

Harmanpreet Kaur steps down as India captain

NEW DELHI: India's only World Cup-winning women's cricket captain Harmanpreet Kaur on Tuesday stepped down from her position in all three formats, saying that she has done her duty as leader and is now "ready to play for the love of the game again."

The 37-year-olds' announcement came after a BCCI review meeting in Guwahati to evaluate the team's trajectory in the past few months. Chaired by BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia, the meeting was attended by Harmanpreet, vice-captain Smriti Mandhana and head coach Amol Muzumdar.

Mandhana, who has recently been vocal about her ambitions to lead the 'Women in Blue', is the front-runner to take over as the next



captain. "Today, I step down as captain of the Indian Women's Cricket Team across all formats," Harmanpreet, who has been enduring a lean patch for a while now, wrote in an Instagram post. "This is not an easy decision. It carries years of memories, emotions, sacrifices, and moments that will stay with me for the rest of my life," added the right-hander, who had earlier spoken about wanting to lead the team till at least the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics for which India have already qualified. Harmanpreet led the Indi-

an T20 side for a decade, taking over as skipper in 2016. She was elevated to ODI captaincy in 2022 before becoming the all-format leader in 2023.

"I feel I have done my duty. I gave this team everything I had. I carried the responsibility with pride, and I will always be grateful for the privilege of leading Indian women's cricket," said the player who hails from Moga in Punjab. She will, however, continue to play for India across formats. "Now, it is time for me to turn the page. Captaincy may end today, but my love for Indian cricket never will. Blood. Sweat. Sacrifice. Pride. I gave it all. Now, I'm ready to play for the love of the game again. Captaincy ends. The journey continues," she said.

TPL: Bopanna to represent Gurgaon Grand Slammers

MUMBAI: Former world No. 1 Rohan Bopanna and 2023 Australian Open men's doubles winner Rinky Hijikata were on Tuesday revealed as marquee players of their respective teams at the Tennis Premier League (TPL) ahead of the player auction on October 12 in Mumbai.

Bopanna will represent Gurgaon Grand Slammers. "Every year, the league gets stronger, and I love the team environment and energy the format brings. This year, the competition will be very high, with a great mix of experienced players and young Indian talent," said Bopanna. Argentina's world No. 60 Roman Burrruchaga, representing



the Kolkata Thunder Blades, will be the highest-ranked singles player in the league.

Hijikata, who will represent the Rajasthan Rangers, has already tasted Grand Slam success. He also reached the 2025 Wimbledon men's doubles final and achieved a career-high doubles ranking of world No. 23. "I'm really excited to be part of the Rajasthan Rangers and make my Kia TPL debut

this season. The 25-point format makes the league very exciting, and I'm looking forward to experience the energy in Hyderabad." Frenchman Terence Atmane, nicknamed "The Magician", will headline the Mumbai Royals. The Lucknow Blazers will be represented by Czechia's Dalibor Svrčina, who returns for a second consecutive season with the same team.

Croatia's Dino Prizmic will be the marquee player for the Hyderabad Strikers. A former junior world No. 1 and the 2023 Roland Garros boys' singles champion, the 21-year-old reached a career-high ranking of world No. 70 this year.

Second U-19 Youth Test Baloda's spell leaves Australia reeling at 86/4

AHMEDABAD: Tanmay Baloda completed a 10-wicket match haul with another four-for in the second innings to leave Australia U-19 reeling at 86 for four, trailing by another 55 runs against India in their second Youth Test here on Tuesday.

Baloda, who had returned 6/32 on the opening day to help India bowl out Australia for a mere 174, kept the hosts in complete control of the game with another terrific performance, taking 4/26 to snare all four wickets in the second innings here at the B Ground of the Narendra Modi Stadium.

Eli Brain waged a lone battle with a 35-ball 39 studded with eight fours for the visiting batters, who once again cut a sorry figure, as the young left-arm orthodox spinner from Haryana ruled the roost. Earlier on the opening day, Australia were bowled out for 174 and India had taken a huge lead of 141 runs in the first innings. In the second, Baloda never

allowed the Australian batters to settle as he struck on the final ball of his first over, getting Hayden Barbulovic (9) caught by Aryan Yadav. Baloda then cleaned up Neel Patel (3) for his second scalp in the eighth over and in the 14th, he pinned Australia captain and opening batter Matthew Lough (8) leg-before for nine. Before the stumps were drawn for the day, Baloda provided the key wicket of Brain to keep India in firm control. Earlier, India were bolstered by half-centuries from skipper Yashbardhan Chauhan (52) and wicketkeeper-batter Abhipray Biswas (73 off 62 balls; 11 fours, 2 sixes) to make 315.

BRIEF SCORES:

Australia U-19 174 & 86/4 in 26 overs (Eli Brain 39; Tanmay Baloda 4/26) trail India 315 in 78.4 overs (Yashbardhan Chauhan 52, Abhipray Biswas 73; Spencer Green 7/110) by 55 runs.



2nd National Ranking TT C'ships - U-11 qualifiers

Telangana's Jatin Jairam secures spot in main draw

PANCHKULA: Young paddlers displayed immense resilience on the opening day of the second National Ranking Table Tennis Championships at the Tau Devi Lal Indoor Hall on Tuesday, with several rising stars pulling off hard-fought comeback victories to secure main-draw berths in the Under-11 categories.

In the U-11 boys' qualifiers, Telangana's Jatin Jairam booked his spot by clinching a nail-biting decider 12-10 against Rigved Saha, alongside compatriot Srikara Varshik and Assam's Nulupal Gohain, who also advanced following hard-fought five-game encounters.

Uttar Pradesh's Viraj Singh headlined the day's action by staging a brilliant recovery

from two games down to edge Tamil Nadu's Aarav Aj in a tense five-game thriller. Goa's Aarish Shaikh similarly survived a grueling five-game battle against West Bengal's Ryan Karmakar.

Other notable qualifiers included West Bengal's Sarabjeet Sarkar and Parthiv Das, who overcame stiff resistance from T Veera Sathvik and M. Tasvanth. The U-11 girls' qualifiers witnessed matching drama as Anika Maheshwari, Arrietri Pal, and Shivangi Mishra all overturned early deficits after dropping the first two games to secure their places in the main draw. Close encounters also favored Dhadkan Tanna, Vedanshi Bolishetty, and Riddhi Singh, who all held their nerve in deciding fifth games.

Renova Masters Super Cricket League begins today

HYDERABAD: The Renova Masters Super Cricket League (MSL) is set to provide cricket enthusiasts and former aspiring cricketers with a platform to showcase their talent, following the launch of the Masters Cricket Association of Hyderabad (MCAH).

The MSL trophy was unveiled at a grand event held at SLN Terminus, Marriotti, Gachibowli, with film actor Ali inaugurating the programme by lighting the ceremonial lamp.

The five-day MSL begins October 7 at Prime Arena with seven teams—KLR Transformers, Maa Spaces, Raging Bulls, Super LED Bullets, Suncrest Warriors, Terminus and Reet Mavericks.

OU Inter-College Carroms C'ship



BHAVANS VIVEKANANDA COLLEGE CROWNED CHAMPS

HYDERABAD: Bhavans Vivekananda College, Sainikpuri, emerged victorious in the OU Inter-College Carroms Championship for Men, defeating MJ College of Engineering 2-0 in the final. Pavan and Raju put up an impressive performance for Bhavans, while Ibrahim and Zubair played well for MJ College of Engineering. In the other key match, Dr. B R Ambedkar College defeated MJPTBCWREI, Medak, 2-0. Jaswanth played a strong game for Dr. B R Ambedkar College, while Nova represented MJPTBCWREI. The championship was organised by IIMC College. Dr Raghuvver, Principal, IIMC College, was the Chief Guest and presented the prizes to the winners.



TG triumphs at 4th National Sports Aerobics C'ship 2026

HYDERABAD: Telangana emerged overall champions at the 4th National Sports Aerobics, Fitness Aerobics, Step Aerobics & Action Aerobics Championship 2026-27, held at G. Pulla Reddy School, Mehdiapatnam, Hyderabad.

Telangana topped the overall standings with 570 points, followed by Tamil Nadu (505) and Andhra Pradesh (480). Telangana athletes secured gold medals across several categories: Gnanvi, Samiksha, Dolly and group (U-8 Girls Sports Aerobics); Adriti Mishra and group (U-10 Girls Fitness Aerobics); Yshvik, Viraj, Arjun, Nandan and Bhargav (U-10 Boys Sports Aerobics); Shanaya Madaan and group (U-11 Girls Fitness Aerobics); Aradhya Jain, Khushvi Malakar, Myra Ahuja and Deeptha Badruka (U-14 Girls Fitness Aerobics); Arni Jain Lajawat (U-18 Girls Sports Aerobics); and Asfa Noor and Areeba Fatima in Step Aerobics Solo.

For the first time in the combined history of Andhra Pradesh and Telangana, the region hosted the national championship, which attracted 365 student participants from seven states—Telangana, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Odisha, Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh.

At the closing ceremony, AISAFA General Secretary Datatreya, Joint Secretary Padma, Vice Presidents Pannier Silven and Parvati, President Magan Lal Ji, General Secretary and AISAFA Joint Secretary Raajsingh, along with SAFAT members Nanhi Singh, Brahmananda Prasad, Mustafa Khan and A Raju, joined the Telangana team for the celebrations.

Parents cannot force adult daughter to live with them: HC

PRAYAGRAJ

DISMISSING a habeas corpus writ petition, the Allahabad High Court has ruled that parents cannot turn to such petitions to force an adult daughter to live with them against her wishes. In an order dated September 28, Justice Sandeep Jain stated, "A major cannot be compelled, against her expressed will to reside with a particular person merely because such person happens to be her parent." The judge dismissed a habeas corpus petition filed by Kalawati Devi who sought the production of her 25-year-old daughter Kumari Pooja before the court, holding that the daughter -- being a major and a competent person -- shall remain at liberty to



reside at the place, and with the person, of her choice.

As per facts of the case, Kalawati Devi had filed a habeas corpus writ petition seeking directions for the production of her daughter before the high court. On August 17, 2026, the court directed the state to produce her. In pursuance of the court order, the daughter was produced in court.

During her interaction with the court, Pooja stated that she is residing independently in Delhi of her own volition and is not in any illegal or unlawful detention. She further stated that she did not wish to reside with her mother.

She alleged that her mother's conduct and behaviour towards her has not been cordial and she has frequent-

The judge dismissed a habeas corpus petition filed by Kalawati Devi who sought the production of her 25-year-old daughter Kumari Pooja before the court

ly been subjected to assault and abuse at her parental home.

On the other hand, the mother denied these allegations and expressed desire that her daughter should reside with her at the parental home.

After interacting with the daughter and considering her statement, the court held that she is a major and has consciously and voluntarily expressed unwillingness to reside with her mother, and dismissed the petition.



PEOPLE BREAK OPEN SCHOOL LOCK, CREMATE MAN IN PREMISES

JAIPUR

A group of people allegedly broke open the lock of a government school in Dudu here and cremated a 20-year-old man on its premises, claiming that the land was earlier used as a cremation ground by their community, police said.

The incident took place on Sunday at Swami Vivekanand Government Model School after Babu, a resident of Mal Ki Dhani, died in a road accident. His family members and other people from the community brought the body to the school and allegedly broke open its lock after a security

guard tried to stop them, police said. SHO Dudu Sanjay Prasad Meena said the group entered the school after breaking the lock and performed the cremation near a tin shed close to the rear gate.

Police reached the spot after being informed, but by then the body had been cremated, he said. The school principal lodged a complaint at Dudu police station alleging trespass and damage to public property against nearly 200 people, the SHO said.

School authorities claimed that the spot where the cremation was performed was used by students as a playground.

Bengal bypoll: Kabir arrested

KOLKATA: West Bengal's bypolls began on a tense note on Tuesday, with a police confrontation leading to the arrest of AJUP chief and MLA Humayun Kabir in Rejinagar and allegations of voter intimidation and polling irregularities surfacing in Nandigram, putting the spotlight on law and order in the two politically sensitive constituencies. Kabir, founder of the Aam Janata Unnayan Party (AJUP), was arrested after a heated exchange with police personnel at his party office in Rejinagar in Murshidabad, hours after accusing the force of acting at the behest of Chief Minister Suvedu Adhikari and urging residents to resist alleged police excesses with mugs (heavy wooden clubs).

The confrontation, which saw police personnel pull Kabir by his shirt and escort him into a vehicle, brought the spotlight on Rejinagar even as his son, Golam Nabi Azad, contested the seat on the AJUP ticket. "The MLA of Nowda (Kabir) has been arrested. Law is equal for everyone, and nobody should try to violate it," Adhikari said after casting his vote in Nandigram.

Murshidabad SP Sachin Makkar said Kabir was neither a candidate in the bypoll nor an authorised election agent and could not move around in the manner he had been doing.

Reports subsequently emerged that he had been arrested on allegations of attempting to influence voters and incite them, though formal details of the arrest were not immediately available.



Ranchi psychiatry institute's intern drugged, raped by PG student

RANCHI

AN intern at the Central Institute of Psychiatry in Ranchi was allegedly raped by a post-graduate student in a hostel room four months ago, police said on Tuesday.

The accused was arrested after the intern filed a zero FIR in a neighbouring state and the case was transferred to the Kanke police station here, a senior officer said.

"We arrested the accused a day after a fresh FIR was registered here on Sunday. The girl was scared and has been going through mental trauma, which caused the delay in reporting the matter to the police," the officer said.

The accused hails from Rajasthan and is a student of



M. Phil Clinical (Post-Graduate), he said.

The intern was allegedly raped on June 28 after she went to the accused's room in the hostel to get information about psychometric test procedures, the officer said.

"According to the complainant, the PG student mixed an intoxicating substance in a glass of water, and she consumed it. During her stay in the room, the PG student allegedly raped her," he said.

Woman, lover booked over suspected murder of husband

MEERUT: A woman and her alleged lover have been booked for the suspected murder of her husband in Meerut after his family raised doubts over his death and claimed she was seen collecting valuables from the house before his burial, police said on Tuesday.

Circle Officer Sangram Singh said Talib, a 30-year-old mason from Fataallahpur under the Lohianagar police station area, died under suspicious circumstances on September 28.

His wife Ilma (27) had told family members that Talib's death was natural, following which relatives took his body to Budhana in neighbouring Muzaffarnagar district and buried it, the officer said.

On October 3, Talib's cousin Akram and other family members approached the police and lodged a complaint alleging that Ilma and a man identified as Aman were involved in his death, Singh said.

A case was subsequently registered under relevant provisions of law, he said. According to police, the family later grew suspicious of Ilma's activities and came to know about her alleged friendship with Aman.

The family has also claimed that Ilma was seen gathering valuables from the house before Talib's body was taken away for burial. They further claimed that local residents had seen Ilma and Aman together on several occasions.

8 BJP candidates file RS nomination papers

LUCKNOW: Eight BJP candidates filed their nominations for Rajya Sabha polls from Uttar Pradesh on Tuesday, even as the opposition Samajwadi Party hinted that it may not force a contest in the October 16 biennial polls. All BJP candidates filed their nominations before the poll returning officer, Ajeet Verma, in the presence of chief minister Yogi Adityanath and other senior leaders.

The candidates are three leaders from the OBC -- UP minister Dharampal Singh (Lodh), OBC wing chief Prakash Pal (Pal), Shruti Gangwar (Kurmi); two from the Dalit community -- Vidya Sagar Sonkar and Priyanka Rawat; and two from the Brahmin community -- Rad-



hakant Ojha, Gopi Krishna Pandey and Ram Pratap Singh Chauhan (Thakur).

"All the candidates filed two sets of nomination papers, each accompanied by signatures of 10 lawmakers as proposers," poll officer Ajit Verma told PTI. Two Samajwadi Party candidates, veteran Ram Gopal Yadav and Reliance Industries executive Dhanraj Parimal Nathwani, have already filed their nominations in Lucknow. Though there were speculations

of the Samajwadi Party fielding a third candidate to force a contest, SP chief Akhilesh Yadav put out a social media post to end the suspense.

"Now, our focus is not on three, but on 403," Yadav said on X before leaving for New Delhi to participate in the opposition protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar. However, the BJP was quick to react to SP's move. "The writing is clear. SP has conceded defeat for 2027 UP polls," Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak said. Tuesday is the last day of filing nominations for 10 Rajya Sabha seats and barring a last-minute change in script, the stage seems set for all 10 candidates to be elected unopposed.



"MSMEs are very important for employment generation, exports, and manufacturing. For this reason, the Prime Minister has introduced several reforms over the past 12 years. The SME Growth Fund (SGF) initiative will serve as a key pillar in advancing the vision of Viksit Bharat @ 2047." -Ashwini Vaishnaw, Union I&B Minister

BIZ BRIEFS

Skoda Slavia prices revealed

Skoda Auto India has announced prices for the new Slavia, with deliveries beginning next week. The 1.0 TSI offers a six-speed manual or an all-new eight-speed torque converter automatic, while the 1.5 TSI is paired with a seven-speed DSG, it is available from launch in six trims. Ashish Gupta, Brand Director, Skoda Auto India, said: "The Slavia has always brought together the qualities customers value in a sedan – timeless design, driving pleasure, comfort, safety and engineering."

Electronics Mart's festive campaign

Electronics Mart India Limited (EMIL) will launch its festive campaign across Bajaj Electronics and Electronics Mart stores from October 11. Customers at Bajaj Electronics in Telangana and Andhra Pradesh can win Rs1 crore cash and 20 Maruti Suzuki Alto K10 cars, while Electronics Mart customers in Delhi-NCR can win Rs50 lakh. The campaign covers electronics, appliances and gadgets, with festive pricing, cashback and no-cost EMI options across the retailer's network of over 190 stores.

ISB's initiative on 25th anniversary

The Indian School of Business (ISB), marking its 25th anniversary, announced initiatives to widen access to management education and strengthen research capacity. Under the ISB25 Scholars Programme, it will award 250 scholarships annually across its PGP and PGP YL programmes, with tuition waivers of up to 100 per cent. ISB will also establish the India Research Commons, providing researchers nationwide access to datasets, research tools and AI-enabled infrastructure, alongside a national faculty development programme for management institutions.

Santoor Scholarship Program opens in AP

Wipro Consumer Care & Lighting and Wipro Cares have opened applications for the Santoor Scholarship Program 2026-27 in Andhra Pradesh. The programme will select 500 young women from economically disadvantaged backgrounds, providing Rs30,000 annually until completion of their undergraduate studies. Applications are open until October 15. Launched in 2016-17, the programme has awarded more than 10,000 scholarships across multiple states and invested over Rs50 crore in women's education over the past decade.

AI+ Smartphone announces offer

AI+ Smartphone has announced festive pricing for its Nova and Pulse series during Flipkart's Big Billion Days 2026. The range includes Pulse 2, Nova 2 5G, Nova 2 Ultra 5G and foldable NovaFlip 5G at. Select models include bank offers. Powered by NxtQuantum OS, the smartphones feature large batteries, 50MP cameras, AMOLED displays and 5G connectivity. Offers are available for a limited period on Flipkart while stocks last.

Tea Board drives India's tea industry towards higher value, global reach

PRODUCTIVITY, QUALITY, EXPORTS AND SMALL GROWERS REMAIN KEY PRIORITIES

GOUDA SWIYACHANDRA
KOLKATA

INDIA'S tea industry, built on a legacy of nearly 200 years, continues to play a significant role in the country's economy, employment and international trade. With the Tea Board of India leading efforts to strengthen the sector, the industry is focusing on higher productivity, quality improvement, exports, small tea growers and value-added products.

Established under the Tea Act, 1953, the Tea Board is the apex body responsible for

the overall development and promotion of the tea industry. Headed by a Chairman, the Board has 31 members representing different segments of the tea industry and Parliament. Its mandate includes increasing tea production, productivity and quality, promoting cooperation among growers, registering and licensing manufacturers, and improving the marketing of Indian tea in domestic and international markets. India produces around 1,396 million kg of tea annually, accounting for about 21% of global production. The coun-



try has around 1,567 organised tea estates and exports more than 285 million kg of tea every year. The industry provides livelihoods to more than 10 million people, with

women constituting around 58% of its workforce.

Tea cultivation is concentrated mainly in Assam, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Kerala, which are known

for their distinctive varieties and growing conditions. At the same time, small tea growers have emerged as an important segment, contributing more than 50% of the country's total tea production. Their growing role has increased the need for better market access, technological support and collective organisation.

India's tea heritage is also reflected in its Geographical Indications (GIs). Darjeeling Tea became the first Indian tea to receive GI registration in 2004, followed by Kangra in 2005 and Assam and Nilgi-

ri teas in 2009. These regional identities help promote the uniqueness and reputation of Indian teas in global markets.

The Tea Development and Promotion Scheme is aimed at strengthening the industry further. It supports replanting of old and senile tea bushes, increasing production and productivity, particularly of Orthodox and Green Tea, and empowering small growers through Self-Help Groups and Farmer Producer Organisations. The scheme also focuses on boosting exports through value addition, improved quality and branding.

Digital technologies are being promoted to improve extension services, information dissemination and service delivery. Research and development, quality assurance, pest management and compliance with residue standards are additional priorities.

With greater emphasis on innovation, sustainability, worker welfare and value-added products, the Tea Board is seeking to strengthen India's position as a major global tea producer and exporter while preserving the country's rich tea-growing heritage.

Oil below \$100 gives D-Street breathing room

SENSEX GAINS 685 POINTS AS BANKS AND RELIANCE LEAD REBOUND

MUMBAI

MARKET benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty ended sharply higher on Tuesday, extending their rally for the second straight session, as a decline in crude oil prices below USD 100 per barrel and buying in bank stocks and Reliance Industries added to investors' optimism.

The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 685.34 points, or 0.95 per cent, to settle at 73,067.81. The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 220.35 points, or 0.98 per cent, to end at 22,776.10. From the 30 Sensex firms, Trent surged the most by 12.78 per cent. Kotak Mahindra Bank, Hindustan Unilever, Reliance Industries, InterGlobe Aviation, Eternal and Asian



Paints were also among the winners. Tech Mahindra, Titan, Bajaj Finance and ITC were among the laggards. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, tanked 1.70 per cent to USD 98.59 per barrel. "Indian equities extended their rebound for a second consecutive session on Tues-

day, with benchmark indices closing higher as further decline in crude oil prices eased some of the macroeconomic pressure weighing on sentiment," Ponmudi R, CEO of Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said. "Crude oil prices slipped below the USD 100

mark after a large G7 stockpile release and alternative supplies through pipelines helped offset disruptions to vessel movements through the Strait of Hormuz. "Coupled with strong Q2 business updates from financials and retail along with supportive global cues, the decline in oil prices improved investors' sentiment and supported a rebound from the oversold levels," Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Ltd, said. The BSE Small-Cap Select index jumped 1.25 per cent and the Mid-Cap Select index 1 per cent. Among the BSE sectoral indices, Telecommunication surged 2.33 per cent, Capital Goods 1.79 per cent, Industrials 1.62 per cent, FMCG 1.57 per cent, Power 1.21

per cent, Oil & Gas 1.21 per cent and Insurance 1.06 per cent. Realty, IT, PSU Bank, Hospitals, Focused IT, Mid-Small Private Banks Quality Tilt and MidSmall Private Banks ended lower. In Asian markets, Japan's Nikkei 225 index and Hang Seng index ended in positive territory, while South Korea's Kospi settled lower. Markets in Europe were trading higher. US markets ended higher on Monday. Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) offloaded equities worth Rs 4,699.14 crore on Monday, according to exchange data. On Monday, the Sensex jumped 472.77 points, or 0.66 per cent, to settle at 72,382.47. The Nifty climbed 133.80 points, or 0.60 per cent, to end at 22,555.75.

Aviation ministry puts brakes on Adani Airports' Mumbai flight shift plan

Partial international operations shift to Navi Mumbai may be delayed by a few weeks

NEW DELHI

THE civil aviation ministry on Tuesday asked Adani Airports to delay the proposed partial shifting of international flights from Mumbai to Navi Mumbai airport, and discussions will be held to chart out the transition plan, according to sources. Adani Airport Holdings Ltd (AAHL) has asked airlines to cut 33 per cent of their international flights to Navi Mumbai airports or discontinue them by October 25, a proposal that has been opposed by the airlines. AAHL, which operates both Mumbai and Navi Mumbai airports, is set to start renovation of



the Mumbai airport's Terminal 1, due to which it has proposed partial shifting of the flight operations. To discuss the issues, Civil Aviation Secretary Samir Kumar Sinha chaired a meeting with representatives of airlines, AAHL, Federation of Indian Airlines (FIA), global airlines' grouping IATA and Airports Authority of India (AAI), among others, in the national capital on Tuesday. The sources said that the

secretary has proposed delaying the transition by a few weeks and has also asked for a firm plan from airlines as well as the airport operator for shifting operations to the Navi Mumbai International Airport. Airlines and AAHL will hold discussions on October 13 on the transition plan, and another meeting will be convened on October 20 to decide on the final contours. At the meeting, AAHL executives outlined its preparedness for handling up to 5 million international passengers annually at the newly commissioned NMIA. They also mentioned the airport's readiness, supported by key infrastructure and passenger

amenities, including robust airport connectivity, in-flight catering facilities, hotels, lounges, and other supporting services, according to the sources. During the meeting, which went on for nearly 90 minutes, AAHL engaged with airlines' representatives and sought to address their operational concerns as well as respond to queries related to the proposed transition and redevelopment plan. The discussions were constructive, with all stakeholders reaffirming their commitment to ensuring a smooth and coordinated transition while maintaining passenger convenience and operational efficiency, the sources said.

ICEA bats for lower GST on mobile phones

HANS BUSINESS
HYDERABAD

THE India Cellular and Electronics Association (ICEA) has urged the government to cut GST on mobile phones to 5 per cent from 18 per cent and place the proposal before the next GST Council meeting. ICEA said high handset prices continue to limit smartphone adoption, with an estimated 250 million Indians still using feature phones. Lower taxes, it said, could improve affordability, particularly for first-time buyers and lower-income households. India is now the world's second-largest mobile-phone manufacturer by volume, and mobile phones became the country's largest export product in FY2025-26.

FinMin pushes private banks to widen financial inclusion

NEW DELHI

THE Finance Ministry on Tuesday urged private sector banks to increase their participation in financial inclusion schemes including Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana (PMMY) and Stand Up India.

Chairing a review meeting with heads of all Public Sector Banks (PSBs) and senior officials of major private sector banks (PVBs), Financial Services Secretary Sanjay Lohiya urged banks to participate wholeheartedly in the forthcoming Financial Inclusion saturation campaign from October 21 to December 31. Lohiya asked private sector banks to give more thrust to serving marginalised sections of society and fulfilling their banking needs. During the

meeting, a detailed review of the progress under various Financial Inclusion schemes including Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana (PMJDY), Pradhan Mantri Jeevan Jyoti Bima Yojana (PMJJBY), Pradhan Mantri Suraksha Bima Yojana (PMSBY), Atal Pension Yojana (APY) and Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana (PMMY), the finance ministry said in a statement. The meeting also reviewed progress on Stand Up India, PM Street Vendor's Atma Nirbhar Nidhi (PM SVANidhi), PM Vishwakarma, PM Surya Ghar, and Kisan Credit Card, it said. The progress of opening brick-and-mortar branches of banks and deployment of Banking Correspondents in unbanked villages was also reviewed, it said.

DraperU concludes Demo Day

HANS BUSINESS
HYDERABAD

DRAPERU India concluded its latest Founders Program with a Demo Day in Hyderabad, where 13 startups pitched to more than 150 investors, venture capitalists and industry leaders.

Ordo and WearSynapse secured investment commitments of Rs25 lakh each from DraperU India and were also selected to represent India at Draper University's Hero Training Program in Silicon Valley. The startups also received an investment commitment from Rathnakar-Samavedam of Hyderabad Angels. Ordo, WearSynapse and Creator Studio shared a ₹90,000 IDFC FIRST Bank prize pool, receiving Rs50,000, Rs25,000 and Rs15,000, respectively. The Demo Day marked the end of a 12-day residential program focused on product development, business models, go-to-market strategy, fund-raising and investor engagement.

World Bank lifts India growth outlook

NEW DELHI

THE World Bank on Tuesday raised India's GDP growth forecast for the current fiscal to 7.1 per cent, up 0.5 percentage points from its projections in April, supported by robust domestic demand and strong exports, despite global headwinds.

India remains one of the fastest-growing major economies in the world and a key contributor to global growth, the multilateral organisation said in its latest India Development Update. "We have upgraded our FY27 growth forecast to 7.1 per cent from 6.6 per cent in April, as growth has held up better than expected despite trade and geopolitical uncertainties," it said. India's growth accelerated to 7.8 per cent in FY26 from 7.2 per cent in FY25, driven by strong investment and solid private consumption, as favourable policy and credit environment outweighed trade tensions. The medium-term prospects are

India is among the top 10 leading emerging-market performers in AI readiness

NEW DELHI: INDIA is among the top 10 leading emerging-market performers in artificial intelligence (AI) readiness and is well positioned to harness the technology, helped by its large technical workforce, globally integrated IT sector and digital public infrastructure, the World Bank said on Tuesday.

In its latest report titled India and Artificial Intelligence: Seizing the Development Opportunity, the World Bank said private investment in AI in India more than tripled to USD 4.1 billion in 2025 from USD 1.2 billion in 2024. The number of professionals employed by Global Capability Centres (GCCs) also rose to

2.36 million in 2025 from 1.9 million a year ago. The report, however, noted that the long-term economic and labour market impact of AI remains uncertain. It called for measures to deepen AI-enabling infrastructure, improve the business environment, broaden access to AI and enhance labour capacity.

strong, the World Bank said, but also cautioned that external risks are elevated, including downside risks related to global oil prices, El Nino, and stock market corrections that would result in capital flow volatility. It noted that rural consumption initially outpaced urban demand supported by strong agricultural performance, while urban consumption strengthened later in the year following in-

come-tax relief and GST cuts. The momentum has carried into FY27, with GDP growing 7.8 per cent in Q1, above expectations, before moderating in subsequent quarters, it said. Private consumption is expected to remain the main driver of growth although a rainfall deficit through August is likely to weigh modestly on rural demand, while subdued government consumption will stay muted, it said. The

investment outlook is broadly unchanged, with heightened global uncertainty weighing on private investment as frontloading fades, partly offset by supportive financial and policy conditions, including stronger public investment, it said. India's exports have performed better than expected and are likely to provide the main upside to the FY27 growth outlook relative to the April forecasts, it said.





‘Jailer 2’ trailer released; Rajinikanth returns in larger than life format

The much-anticipated trailer for the sequel to ‘Jailer’ has been released in the Telugu version. Superstar Rajinikanth plays the central character Muthuvel Pandian, a larger than life prison warden in the film directed by Nelson Dilipkumar. The trailer gives away that the sequel will be a bigger version of the original with enhanced action, comedy and entertainment quotient.

It shows that while a fresh conflict is in the offing, the comedy continues to be in the breezy offbeat style of the director. Rajinikanth is in full command of his powers as he displays the same bravado and comic timing that made the first film a blockbuster. The expansion of the universe also indicates that the second film has bigger plans for the hero than the first.

The film also stars S.J. Suryah, Vidya Balan, Shivarajkumar, Mohanlal, Ramya Krishnan, Yogi Babu, Suraj Venjaramoodu and Mirnaa along with the superstar in crucial roles.

Anirudh Ravichander has composed the music. Vijay Kartik Kannan has handled cinematography and R. Nirmal has edited. It is produced by Kalanithi Maran of Sun Pictures and is ready for a global theatrical release. In Telugu states it is being presented by Sithara Entertainments in the Telugu version in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana.

The film is touted to be big on action with a unique mix of comedy and stars Rajinikanth and Nelson Dilipkumar who are coming together for the second time after Jailer. ‘Jailer 2’ will release in theatres on 15th October.



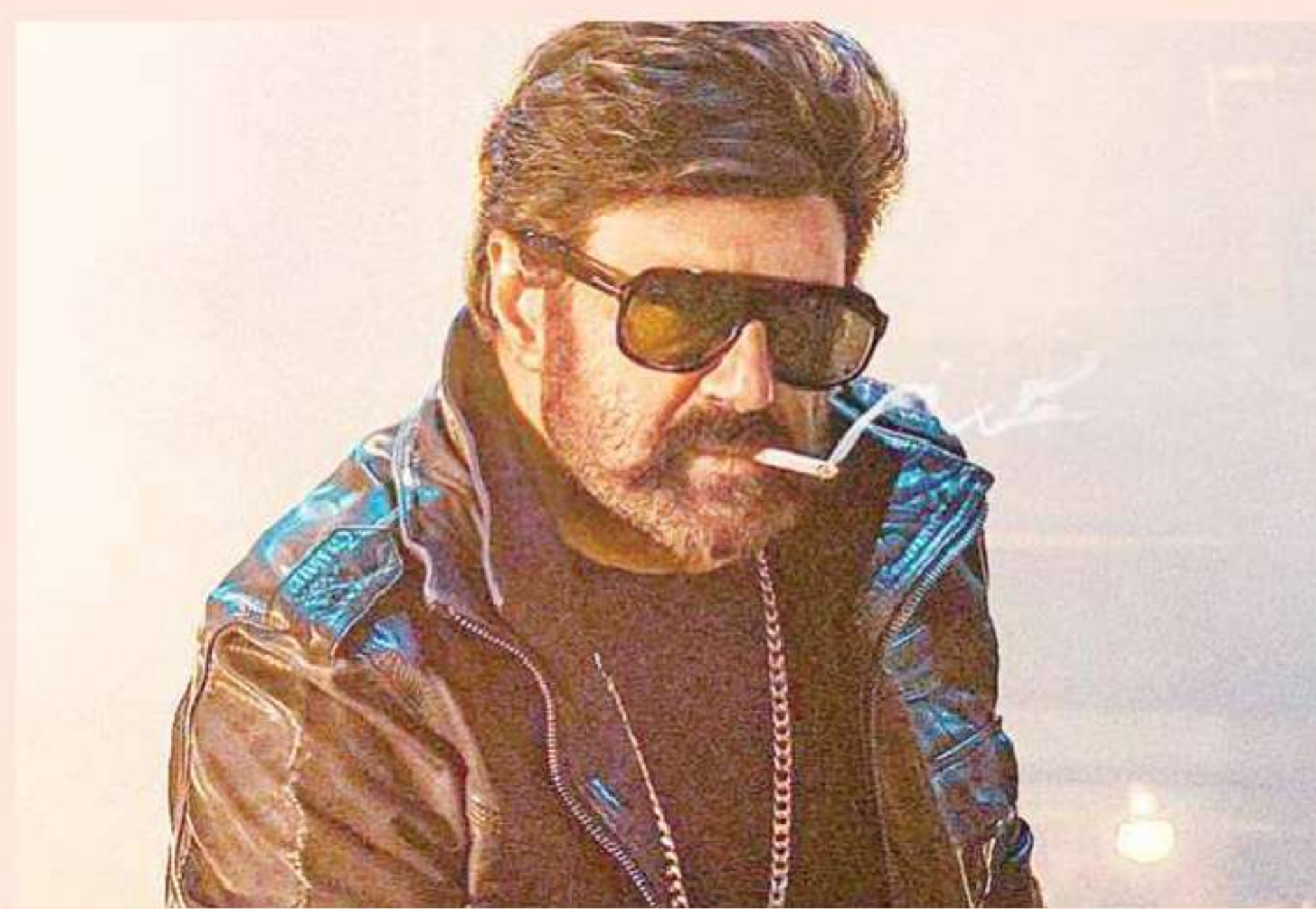
Balakrishna back on sets of ‘Dada’ after recovery

Nandamuri Balakrishna is back on the sets of his upcoming mass entertainer Dada in Mysore after recovering from an injury. The film directed by blockbuster filmmaker Gopichand Malineni is all set for a grand theatrical release on December 24.

The Mysore schedule which is going to be a long one will see the makers wrapping up important talkie scenes with Balakrishna and some of the other big stars.

Produced by Venkata Satish Kilaru under Vridhi Cinemas, Dada sees the iconic star and director Gopichand Malineni coming together for the second time after Veera Simha Reddy.

The makers have already released Entry Of An Era of the film along with the title announcement which



created enormous hype. While Balakrishna looked dashing in the stills, the name The King Of Chaos created massive talking points.

The film also stars

Manoj Manchu and Kajal Aggarwal apart from the lead hero. S Thaman has scored the music while Arvind S Kashyap has been behind the camera. Navin Nooli has edited the

film and Sai Madhav Burra has written the dialogues.

With Balakrishna resuming the shootings, Dada is all set to dazzle the viewers during the Christmas season.

All set for ‘Ranabaali’ trailer launch

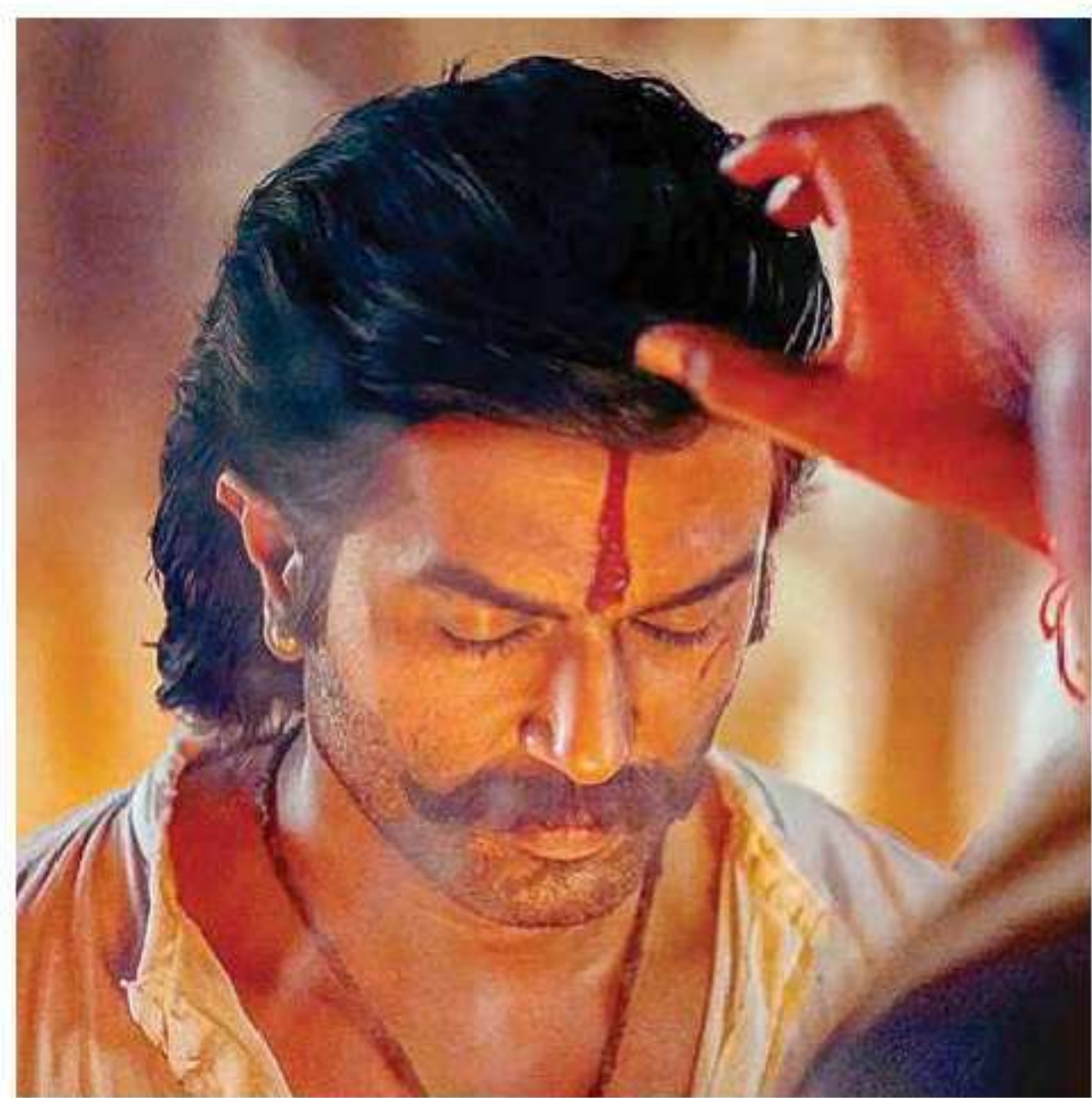
The much-awaited trailer of ‘Ranabaali’, starring Vijay Deverakonda and Rashmika Mandanna, will release on October 8, the makers announced. The Pan-India period film, which has been garnering attention with the release of its teaser and songs, is all set to hit the theatres across the world on October 16, coinciding with Vijayadashami.

The trailer will help boost the viewership of the film, which has been finding extensive talk on social media even before its release. The promotions of the film, which also star Rashmika and Vijay Deverakonda, have been creating a lot of hype as well. This has in-

creased the curiosity for the film, especially since its been a while since its release.

Set in the 19th century, ‘Ranabaali’ is based on true events that transpired in British India between 1854 and 1878. The film also promises to be a massive period piece with an intriguing historical storyline with a massive scale production value. The film, presented by T-Series, is produced by Naveen Yerneni and Y. Ravi Shankar under the Mythri Movie Makers banner, and is the latest venture from them.

With the ‘Ranabaali’ trailer set to release on October 8, followed by the film a week later, the hype for the film keeps building up as every day passes.



‘Mayookha’ locks Oct 9 release

The upcoming thriller ‘Mayookha’ starring Payal Chengappa is all set for a grand World premiere on October 9. Directed by Sri Tej S.K, this suspense-filled flick is presented by Sasidhar Nalla under the Prashvitha Entertainment banner. They have now released an overseas update as Cognier Cine Creations will be distributing ‘Mayookha’ globally. The news is quite surprising and will create quite an interest across the globe. Presented as a unique thriller, the film has created a lot of buzz after the release of their recent trailer. As the makers have dropped a solid trailer, the viewers are now more excited to witness the film’s theatrical release.

Also, the film has quite an advantage as this week itself, the release of the much-anticipated film ‘Aadarsha Kutumbam’ of Venkatesh and Trivikram is postponed. So, the viewers who were going to watch the film have now shifted their attention towards ‘Mayookha’ which has created a good first impression on the viewers.

‘Hanuman Ansh’ Telugu trailer offers glimpses of Neem Karoli Baba’s life

The trailer of Hanuman Ansh Telugu version, the biopic on the life and times of spiritual guru Neem Karoli Baba, has been released. The movie is set to hit the Telugu screens on October 9 amidst great fanfare after its successful Hindi theatrical run.

Hombale Films is releasing the film in Telugu. Written and directed by Dr. Vishal Chaturvedi, the bio-pic is all set to hit the screens in October. Dr. Vishal Chaturvedi’s film features Shobinav Satya as the title character Neem Karoli Baba, also endearingly called as Maharaj-ji by his followers. Chandan Anand and Purnima Tiwari play significant roles in the spiritual drama.

The recently unveiled Hanuman Ansh Telugu trailer provides a sneak peek into the life of Neem Karoli Baba, while simultaneously showcasing the film’s faith and belief-centric theme. The film also aims to take the viewers on a spiritual tour along with the guru, offering a multi-lingual perspective to his multi-continental message. Shreyas Dharmadhikari and Rishi Pathak have provided the soulful music to the film.

Hombale Films acquired the theatrical distribution rights to Hanuman Ansh for the South Indian languages after its successful Hindi run. The film is all set to release in multiple south-Indian languages. With Neem Karoli Baba’s spiritual journey at its core, Hanuman Ansh is all set to make its way to the Telugu audience from October 9.



‘Garividi Lakshmi’ pre-release event held; set for Oct 17 release

‘Garividi Lakshmi’, the upcoming biopic of the legendary folk singer Garividi Lakshmi of Andhra Pradesh, is all set to have its theatrical release on October 17. The film, produced by TG Vishwa Prasad and Kriti Prasad under their People Media Factory banner, is directed by Gauri Naidu Jammu, while Anandi essays the lead role. The makers organized a pre-release event recently, where Adivi Sesh and the directors Bobby Kolli, Harish Shankar and Maruthi, along with the cast and crew, were present. The promotional content, which was released earlier, has already gathered attention from the audiences.

Adivi Sesh praised the film’s authenticity and Anandi’s performance after watching the trailer. He mentioned that the folk songs and culture in the film reminded him of his days

in Visakhapatnam and that he was confident the movie would resonate well with the audiences.

Maruthi, on the other hand, spoke about how he introduced Anandi as a heroine and lauded her transformation for the role. Harish Shankar also appreciated the team for introducing the culture, language and folk music of the people of North Andhra to the masses. Kriti Prasad described Garividi Lakshmi as a story rooted in Indian culture, whereas TG Vishwa Prasad disclosed that Kriti played this project as one of the stories she wanted to narrate.

Anandi mentioned that she worked for nearly two years on the film and considered the role a special opportunity. Charan Arjun, the music director, has composed around 20 songs and the background score.



‘Anakapalli’ team celebrates response, calls for more theatres

The team of ‘Anakapalli’ held a Thank You Meet on Tuesday to thank the people for their overwhelming response to the rustic drama after its first-day theatrical release on October two. The film’s makers and cast expressed their gratitude to the audience for their support while calling for exhibitors to give more screens to the movie.

Actor-producer-director Thrinadha Rao Nakkina said that film is pulling crowds despite the competition after the opening weekend as many shows were houseful. He appreciated the artists for their work and requested the audiences and media to support the film. Producer Kandregula Naidu said that the rustic drama was released in approximately 200 theatres and that they had

worked hard to bring it to the people’s screens. He further said that they were disappointed that despite the film’s positive response, the exhibitors had not given enough screens and requested the distributors to release the film in more screens. Lagadapati Sridhar, whose son Vikram Sahidev stars as the lead hero, said that he believed the movie will become a Dasara Dhamaka. He said that the audience’s support could help smaller films succeed.

Vikram Sahidev thanked the audience, critics, and the general public for their support, while praising Indrāja, Sandhya Vasishtha, Tarak Ponnappa, and composer Davzand for their work on the film. Actress Indrāja said that it was disappointing that a well-received film had not been able to get sufficient theatres, adding that the audiences ultimately judge the film based on its contents.

Mahima Nambiar calls ‘Comrade Kalyan’ a fun entertainer

Actress Mahima Nambiar has joined hands with Sree Vishnu for the first time in Telugu film ‘Comrade Kalyan’ which is a period entertainer laced with humor, romance and drama. The actress said she enjoys the role of comic relief in Sree Vishnu’s style. Directed by Janakiram Marella, the film is presented by Kona Venkat and produced by Venkata Krishna Karnati and Seetha Karnati of Skanda Vahana Motion Pictures LLP. Set to release globally on October 9, Mahima said she has learned Telugu to deliver dialogues in her character Sitara Devi, a innocent girl next door from Odisha, correctly after understanding the language. The actress said Sree Vishnu is spontaneous and mostly improvises his dialogues during the shoot which was fun to work with despite challenges. Mahima added that the comic relief between the lead pair was created using language-based jokes that has been well received by the audience including the song ‘Odiya Pilla’. “I got attracted to the script as the 90s theme and commercial approach was unique. Though it had Naxalism overtones, it was treated in a humorous way without any negative intention,” she added. While talking about her future plans, the actress said she is looking forward to doing different roles in various languages and is currently working on a Malayalam and Tamil projects apart from listening to Telugu scripts.



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